

街头霸王全记录

UNDISPUTED

STREET FIGHTER



这一系列改变游戏史的艺术与创新

STEVE HENDERSHOT

Foreword by Tim Lapetino, author of Art of Atari

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U N D I S P U T E D



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追溯到街头霸王的源头

By Steve Hendershot

VETERAN CAPCOM ILLUSTRATOR SHOEI

Okano held a massive mobile phone to his ear, the cover dangling awkwardly as we ascended a long Tokyo escalator. He was nervous. Akiman wasn't answering.

I was nervous, too.

Akiman, also known as Akira Yasuda, was the chief artist behind *Street Fighter II*. He was the wildcard of my research trip to Japan, a reclusive genius who might or might not be there to welcome us to his apartment. I'd been warned that a no-show was a possibility, but now that I had flown from Chicago to Tokyo in hopes of meeting the creator of Chun-Li, Guile and E. Honda, it would be crushing to miss out.

Okano kept trying to reach Yasuda. When he eventually broke through, he took a deep breath.

Street Fighter II was a global, cultural phenomenon in the 1990s, one that Yasuda had brought to life along with game designer Akira

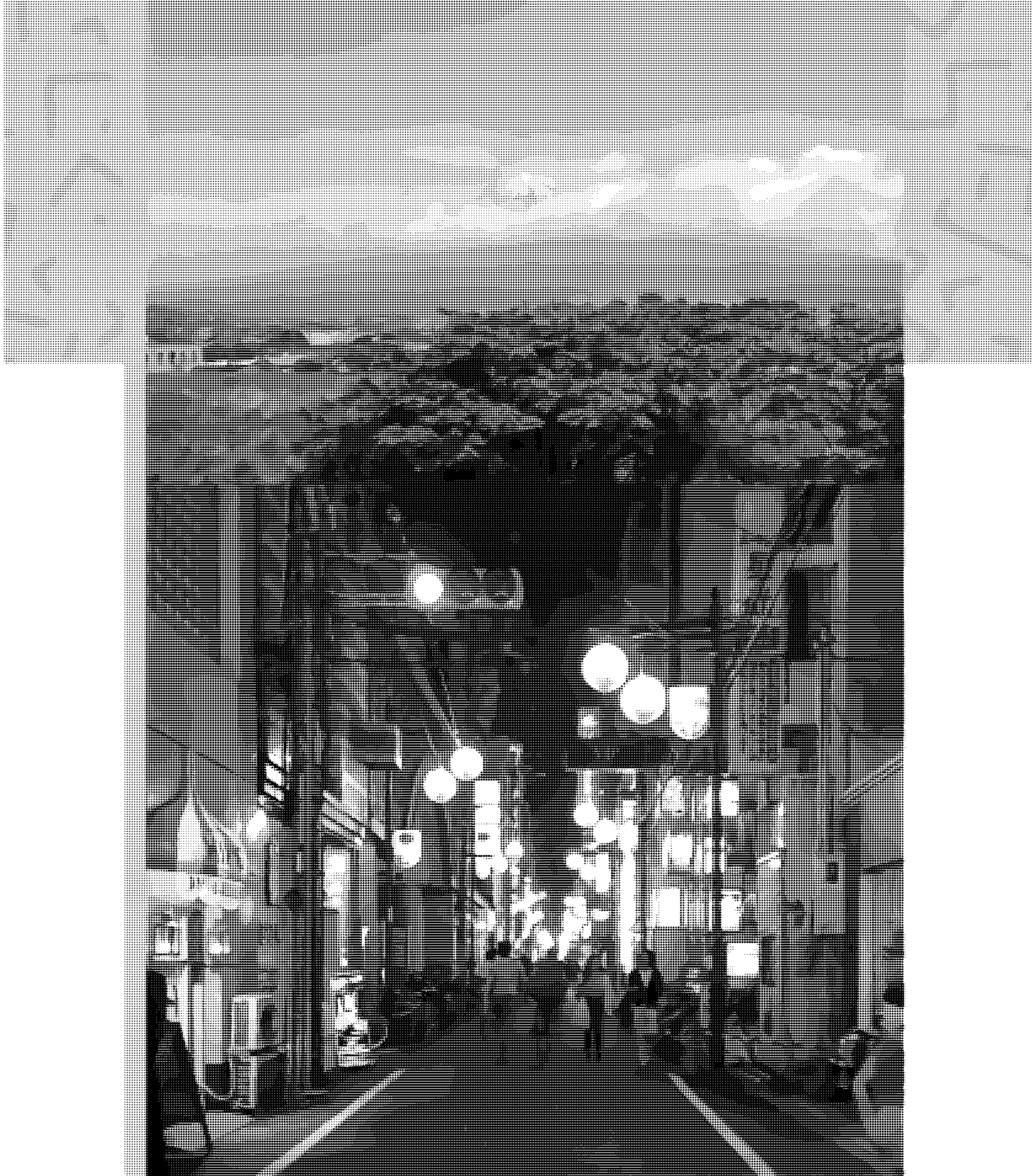
Nishitani. I had experienced its original, massive surge of popularity firsthand as a teenager at my local arcade in Grand Rapids, Michigan.

Now I was working on a 30th anniversary *Street Fighter* book, and by the time of my trip to Japan, I already had spent months obsessing over Yasuda's work, interviewing scores of people about the world he had made. I'd also heard he could be as quirky and unpredictable as the characters he created.

This was my one chance to meet him, and I could feel it slipping away.

Okano chatted for a minute with his old colleague, and then our group of four took a sudden, sharp left turn into a department store—the sort of tricked-out, multi-floor marvel that has mostly disappeared from the United States but is thriving in Japan. Nobody said a word to me as we raced to a second-floor food counter. I was dying for an update when my

上图:(上)动车上拍摄的富士山;
(下)大阪之夜;下页图:(左上)卡
普空大阪收藏的《街头霸王
II》画作;(左下)SHOEI和他绘制
的《街头霸王II:冠军版》封面;
(中)安田朗为《街头霸王II》所
画的隆;(右)安田朗放在东京家
中的代表作:春丽。





我从芝加哥飞往东京,希望见到春丽。
古烈和E本田的创造者Guile and E. Honda.

translator finally turned to me.

She asked if I wanted something to drink.

I ordered poorly. Blame it on nerves, or disorientation. But soon I was sipping on a weird concoction of electric-red fruit juice while everyone else enjoyed smoothies of perfect, bubble tea-grade creaminess. There was an extra smoothie, too, at the edge of the counter.

I soon learned the best news I'd heard all day: It was for Yasuda.

Okano explained that Yasuda would see us—and he wanted a vegetable smoothie. It made a strange kind of sense: a bright green drink for the creator of Blanka.

We headed outside, where Okano began to dash and dart through the streets of Tokyo like he was worried Yasuda would call back and change his mind. I struggled to keep up, but finally we made it, stopping at a 7-Eleven across the street from Yasuda's home to grab another

container of tea. Whatever happened next, we would not be deterred for lack of beverages.

Okano pressed the buzzer, and soon we were inside.

工作室里的艺术家

Entering Yasuda's apartment was like entering Street Fighter university, albeit a somewhat obsessive-compulsive version, where hundreds of coins were stacked meticulously just inside the door, yet the bed was buried in clutter. The place had two focal points. The first was a gaming mecca—a giant flatscreen TV surrounded by dozens of character statues, including one of Yasuda's own, Street Fighter's Sakura. The other was his art studio, located in the second room of the small apartment. There, just a few feet away, rested a life-sized oil painting of Chun-Li.

I had planned to ask about Chun-Li's

design, and specifically how Yasuda had decided to give her those distinctive hair buns. The question answered itself, however, as I looked around his apartment: hair buns were everywhere. There were all manner of paintings and sketches of hair-bunned ladies, and most of them weren't Chun-Li. I asked anyway.

"I was taught they were Chinese. And they're cute. And they're easy to draw. And they look good in dot art," Yasuda explained. "They add personality and character."

That was the opening statement of a master class on character design and fictional world-building. Yasuda went on to explain his theory of character creation and character relationships—how to develop a balanced set of characters who combine to make an imaginary world feel full and rich. We sat on pillows on Yasuda's floor, drank tea and talked for three hours about his creations, philosophies and influences.

街头霸王的制作组和玩家们都为它的变革传承出过力,所以这本书记录了他们两者的故事。

街头霸王职业玩家—日本的"Nemo"(根本直树)和美国的"Li.Joe"(恰拉梅里)在奥兰多社区锦标赛上。



三十年来的两方面创新

This book is a history, celebration and examination of the world Yasuda and Nishitani created. It's been 30 years since the modest success of the first *Street Fighter* game, and 26 years since Yasuda and Nishitani's followup, *Street Fighter II*, became a runaway, global sensation—the sort of epic grand slam that turns a small business like Capcom into a public company with thousands of employees.

"*Street Fighter* is a unique brand because it has such broad appeal," says Kilchiro Urata, CEO of Capcom USA. "This is a series that has stirred passion in fans regardless of their age, gender or nationality over the last 30 years."

This book is about the creativity of *Street Fighter*, however, not its profitability. The series is fascinating not just because it's popular, but because of the ways it changed gaming. First, by popularizing player-versus-player competition, *Street Fighter* not only established a new genre, but also gave new life to a flagging arcade culture.

Second, by presenting an array of memorable fighters to choose from, each with a distinctive style of play, *Street Fighter* offered a world of chess-like complexity. Arcade owners and even Capcom employees worried that the level of depth and difficulty would turn off players, but it delighted them instead.

Finally, by releasing games in quick succession for both arcades and home consoles, *Street Fighter* bridged two eras while showcasing the best aspects of each: the shoulder-to-shoulder dynamic of arcade competition, and consoles' ability to facilitate

hours of dedicated practice.

Street Fighter also innovated in ways its creators didn't anticipate. Player-versus-player competition was an afterthought until Capcom's Japanese developers saw American arcade players embracing the new style; players discovered and created combination moves that the developers didn't know existed; and the pace of gameplay increased thanks to feedback from arcades. *Street Fighter* players also led the way in creating a vibrant, global fighting-game community, one whose popularity helped spur *Street Fighter*'s resurgence in the 2000s.

Because *Street Fighter*'s creators and players share its legacy of innovation, this book tells both of their stories: how the games were made, and how exceptional players turned *Street Fighter* competition into a worldwide spectator sport.

魔幻的储物间

The day before my visit with Akira Yasuda, I had toured Capcom's headquarters in central Osaka, a three-hour train ride south of Tokyo. After buying a mysterious, possibly fish-based product for lunch from a street vendor, I took an elevator to a room where *Street Fighter* artists were busy at work. Some of them were newcomers who had joined the company in the era of *Street Fighter IV* and *V*. Others, like Shoel Okano and Naoto "Bengus" Kuroshima, had been there for nearly all of *Street Fighter*'s 30-year run. I headed to a stockroom in the far corner, the home of Capcom's *Street Fighter* archives.

The room was nondescript, just a large closet with cardboard boxes stacked floor to ceiling. I began opening boxes. There, under

plastic, was a painting of Ryu with his back turned—Yasuda's famous image that graced the arcade cabinet of *Street Fighter II* in 1991. Then Okano held up an illustration he had created for the overseas console-edition cover of *Street Fighter II: Champion Edition*. Next, we unboxed the anime-styled canvases from the *Street Fighter Alpha* games.

To hold these paintings was to feel *Street Fighter*'s handcraftedness. These games didn't emerge from an assembly line or a corporate strategy session. Nishitani and Yasuda were in their 20s when they created *Street Fighter II*, and so were most of the artists who worked for them—as well as their supervisors. They made magic, they made history, and they made something that seemed larger than life when I first encountered the game as a teenager at my hometown arcade.

《街头霸王全记录》概述

This book tells the story of *Street Fighter*'s creation and evolution, and also traces the growth of the competitive *Street Fighter* scene. The fighting-game community that began in arcades like mine has grown into a thriving global network featuring professional players, high-stakes tournaments, and even its own television show.

In addition, we'll look at some of the other creative work that has helped define the series, including comics and manga, action figures, movies, and the art and imagery that have helped *Street Fighter* make an indelible impression on a generation of fans.

We'll also look at the characters who have

《街头霸王V》监制中山贵之展示了升龙拳;《街头霸王II》联合创始人西谷亮放出波动拳;卡普空画师SHOEL致敬了《街头霸王II》中隆龙卷旋风脚的收招动作。

given Street Fighter its unique personality, a challenging but wildly successful balance of playfulness and ferocity. We'll chart the characters' growth over time, often accompanied by insights from their creators. And some of the best Street Fighter players in the world—champions such as Daigo Umehara, Justin Wong and Alex Valle—are on hand to help you understand the strategy required to use those top characters effectively.

One other note here: Although Capcom has generously provided me with access to its Street Fighter staff and artwork, this book is based entirely on my reporting—the final product reflects my point of view as well as the views of the people I interviewed, and doesn't reflect Capcom's official perspective.

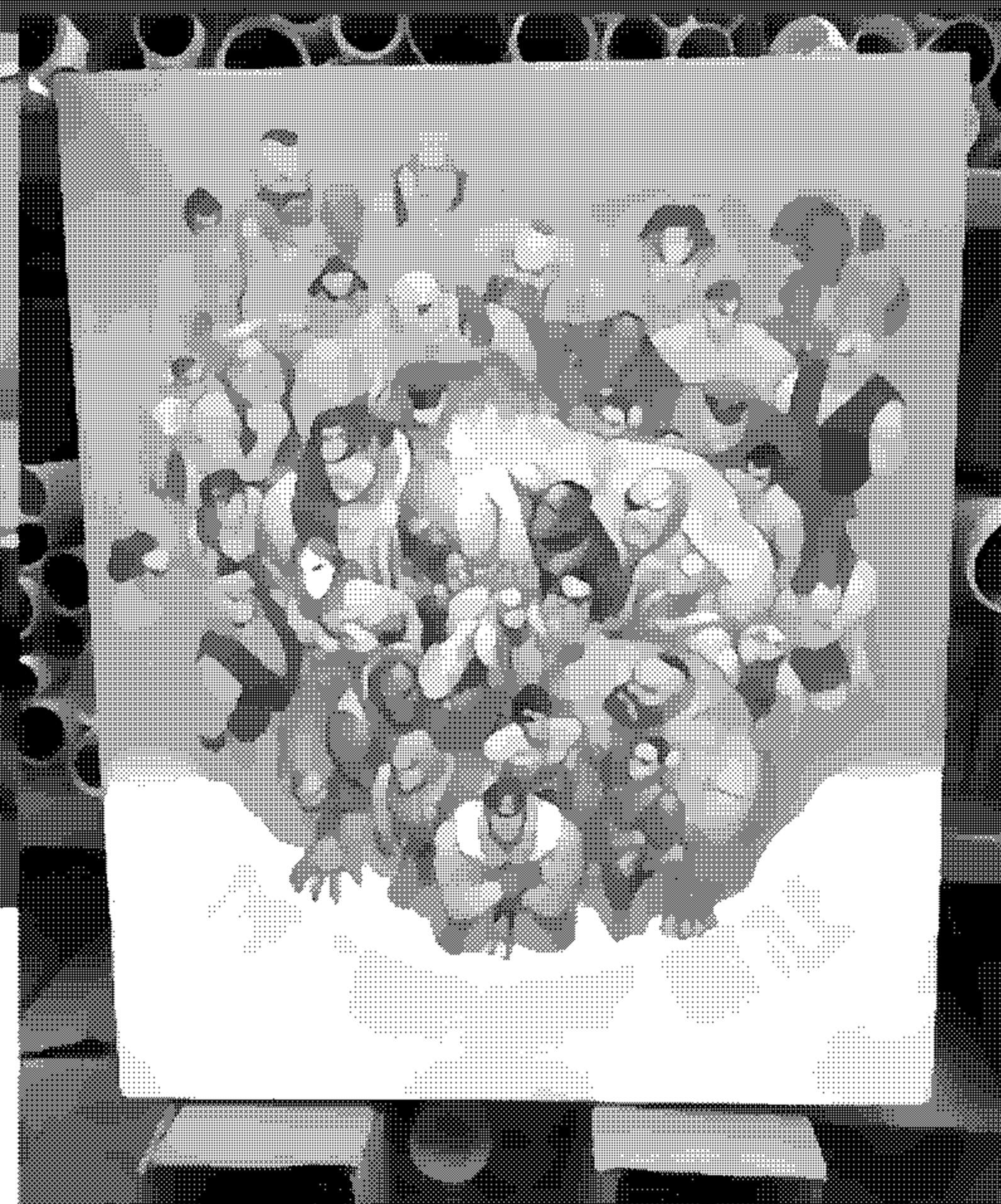
街头霸王之世代

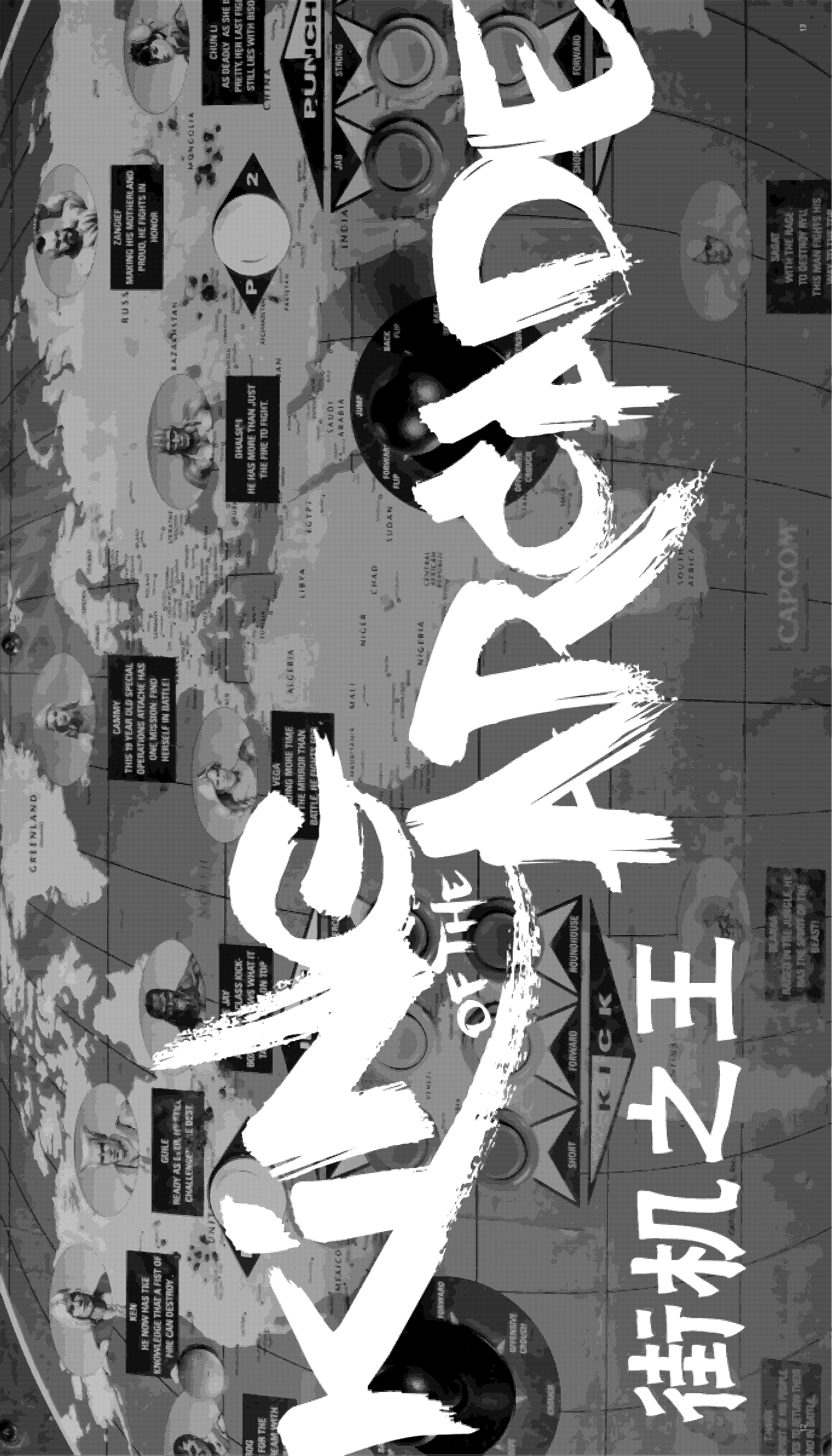
I spent my final afternoon in Japan at Capcom's Tokyo office, meeting with Street Fighter masterminds of different generations: Akira Nishitani, co-creator of *Street Fighter II*, and also Takayuki Nakayama, director of *Street Fighter V*. It was fascinating to hear Nishitani drop pearls of *Street Fighter II* wisdom, and cool to see Nakayama's devotion to learning the lessons and legacy of his predecessors. It was clear that *Street Fighter V* is Nakayama's attempt to capture the magic of Nishitani's and Yasuda's game, and translate it to another era.

It was a fitting end to my Street Fighter sojourn to Japan, and a fine place to start the *Undisputed Street Fighter* story. To quote Ryu in *Street Fighter IV*: "Let's get going!"



卡普空魔幻的储物间里藏有“Daichan”的《街头霸王α》的肯与隆原画(左)和“Bengus”的《超级街头霸王II》全角色图(右)。





ZANGIEF
MAKING HIS MOTHERLAND
PROUD, HE FIGHTS IN
HONOR

GABRIEL
THIS 19 YEAR OLD SPECIAL
OPERATIONS ATTACHE HAS
ONE MISSION: FIND
HIMSELF IN BATTLE

REN
HE KNOWS THE
ADVANTAGE THAT A FIST OF
STEEL CAN DESTROY

GEMLE
READY AS EVER TO MEET
CHALLENGE, HE DOES

RAY
CLASS MICK-
TAKES WHAT HE
CAN GET

DUALSON
HE HAS MORE THAN JUST
THE FINE TO FIGHT

CHEN LI
AS DEADLY AS SHE IS
PRETTY, HER LAST FIGHT
STILL LIES WITH DISO-
CUTNEY

VEGA
FINDING ENOUGH TIME
TO FIGHT MURDER THAN
BATTLE OF DESTINY

PUNCH
STRONG
JUD
INDIA

SPORT
KICK
KICK
KICK

P
2

OF THE

街机之王

Street King

YAMAT
WITH THE BLOOD
OF DESTINY WILL
THIS MAN FIGHT HIS

LAST FIGHT
WITH THE BLOOD
OF DESTINY WILL
THIS MAN FIGHT HIS



KING OF THE ARCADE

一个游戏 驾驭其他

在《街头霸王》之前,街机厅是个混杂的地方,每台机器都独霸一方.但到了1991年,《街头霸王II》将玩家间对战引入了所有街机厅的"熔火核心",那些小块封地都被并入了统一的规则下.在街机厅里,《街头霸王II》的机器就是饰有宝石的王座,而最强者的《街头霸王II》玩家无疑就是这里的王.

SHOEL所画《街头霸王II:冠军版》中正评估对手的隆.

玩家对 玩家

卡普空“有史以来最令人兴奋的专用机”广告中并没有强调《街头霸王》可以进行玩家间对决。

《街头霸王》的街机新动力

STREET FIGHTER II DIDN'T invent head-to-head arcade martial-arts battles—that distinction falls to 1984's *Karate Champ*. But in *Karate Champ* and other early fighting games, the prospect of competing against another person, rather than the machine, was considered an ancillary gimmick. Arcade culture had evolved around the pursuit of high scores, and it was tough for players to abandon that mentality.

Teenager Jack Gale of Miami, Florida, was among the best of the score-chasers of the 1980s, a *Guinness Book of World Records*-verified high-score holder and the king of *Karate Champ*. But he was 21 by 1987, and he stepped away from competitive play right around the time the original *Street Fighter* was released.

The new game was a success, but not a runaway hit. The player-versus-player functionality was catching on in certain arcades, but still secondary to taking on the machine itself. When Gale stopped by his hometown arcade one day that summer, he noticed a crowd gathered around the machine to watch players competing head to head. He sensed that this quirky mode of play had big potential.

“Playing against a human was a completely

different dynamic. The computer was predictable; a human could do anything,” Gale recalls. Then there was the added dimension of body language, and the prospect of reading and manipulating an opponent. He saw the possibilities. He also recognized the additional levels of strategic complexity afforded by the game's control system, which featured six different buttons in addition to a joystick—the most complicated arcade controls he had seen.

“Great players want that added complexity,” says Gale. “More options make it more interesting.”

Gale watched *Street Fighter* at the arcade for a full hour. Then another. He was this close to jumping in, before he turned and walked away.

“If I'd known what it would become, I would have been all in,” he says.

“他们不可能(对街机设计)买账的”

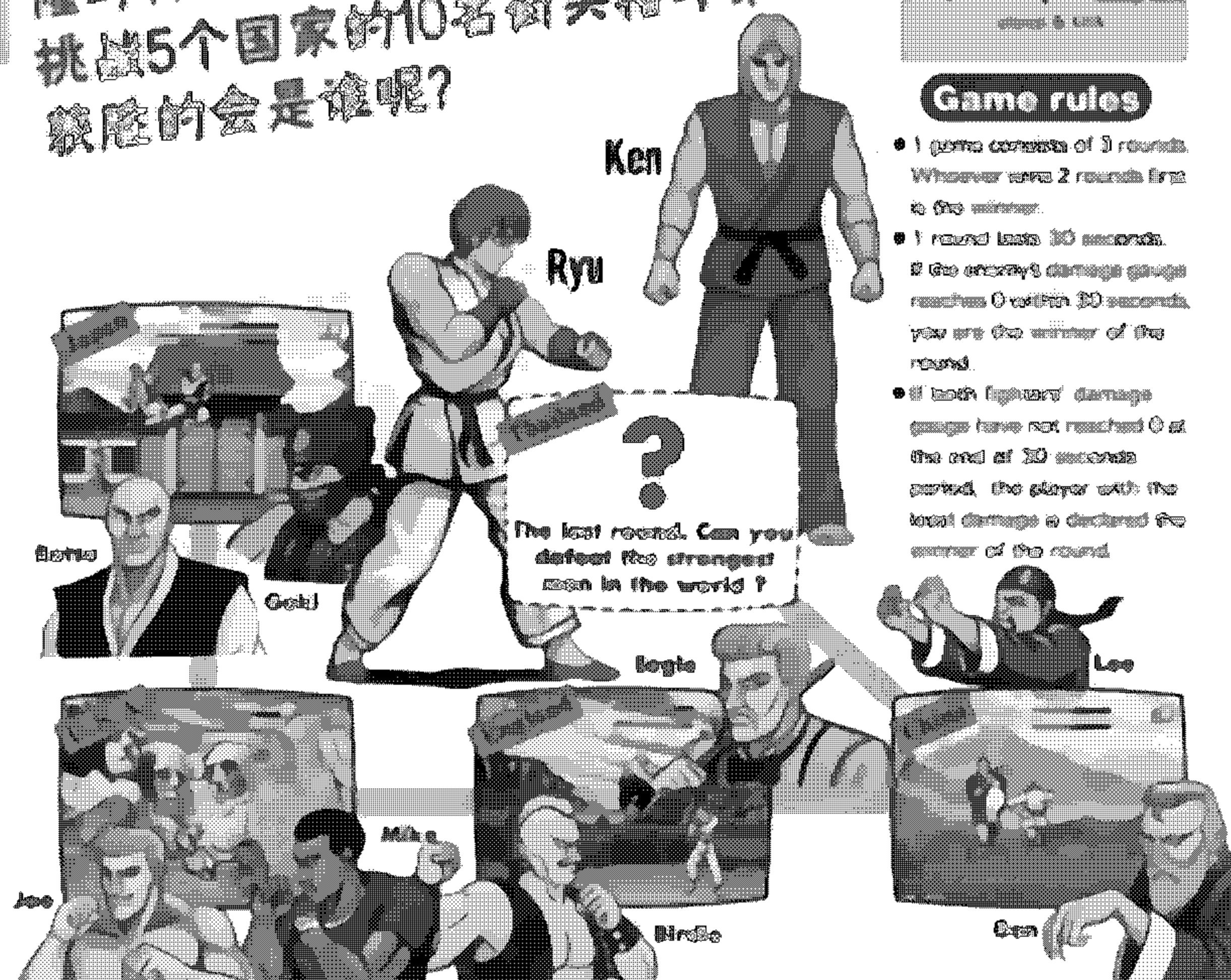
The original *Street Fighter* game was the brainchild of Capcom's Takashi Nishiyama and Hiroshi Matsumoto. It introduced several core elements of the series, such as the characters Ryu, Ken and Sagat; the graffiti-style logo; and special moves such as the Hadoken fireball and Shoryuken rising uppercut, also called

the Dragon Punch. Nishiyama's greatest innovation was the strategic complexity afforded by six buttons, which would accommodate three varieties each of punches and kicks, in addition to the joystick.

It was such a radical idea that Nishiyama anticipated the objections of arcade owners, and devised a way to fold all the extra complexity into a relatively simple-looking arcade cabinet. He envisioned a machine with two big, pressure-sensitive buttons per player. When players tapped a button, their characters would offer a flimsy, light attack. A firmer press produced a medium strike. And if someone lunged at the button with all their might, their character would make his strongest move.

To build the cabinet, Capcom turned to a northern California company with deep Japanese roots. Atari Games' leader was Hide Nakajima, who had previously run Atari's Tokyo subsidiary, then worked at Namco after the companies merged. (Atari Games was Atari's arcade division; its home-console unit, Atari Inc., already was a separate operation.) In 1987, the year of *Street Fighter*'s release, Nakajima led a group of employees who bought enough of Atari's stock to regain the company's independence. And when he inked

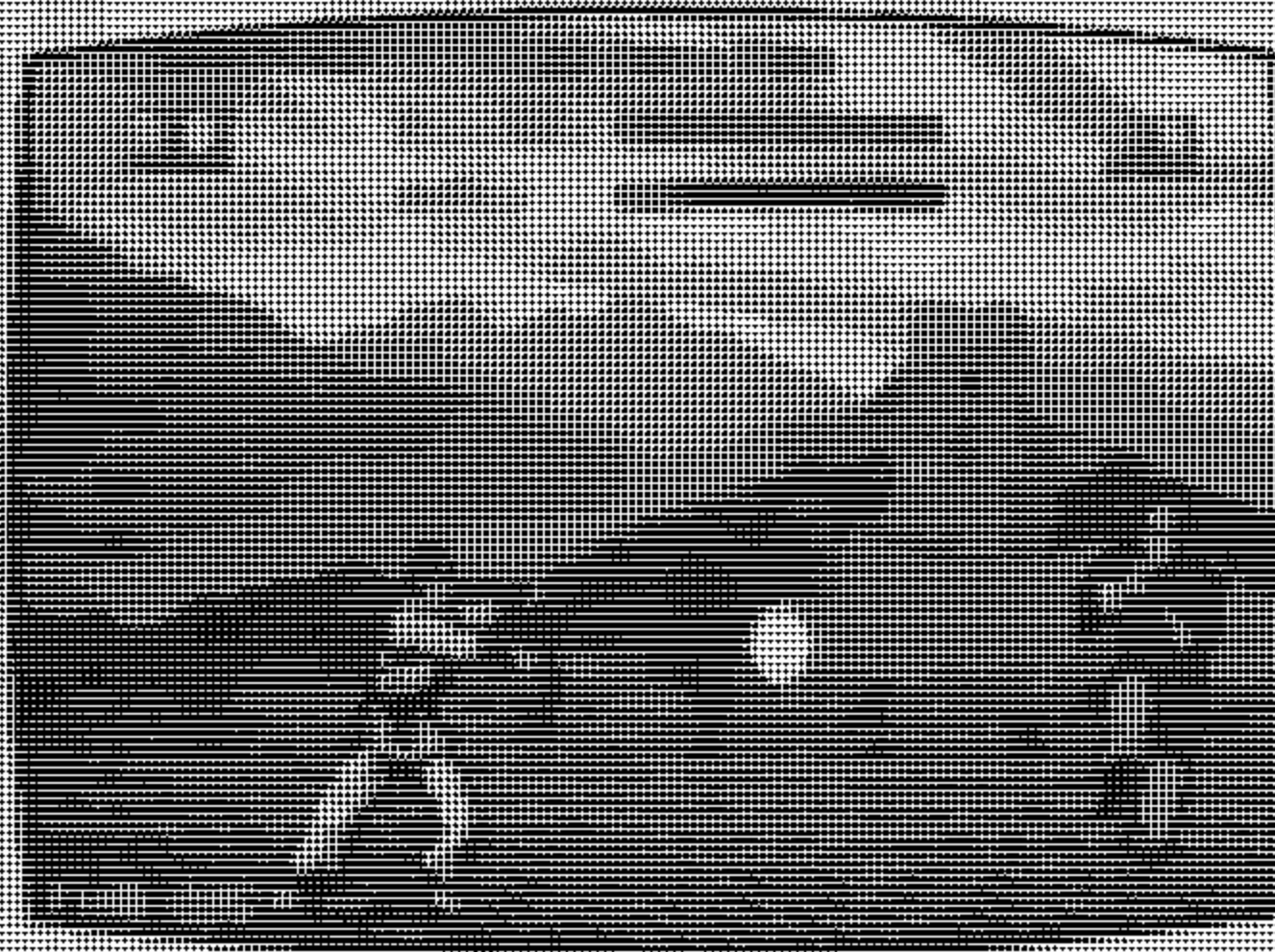
隆与肯一两名年轻的武术大师,将要挑战5个国家的10名街头格斗家。获胜的会是谁呢?



**NOW
ON SALE**

ELECTROCOIN

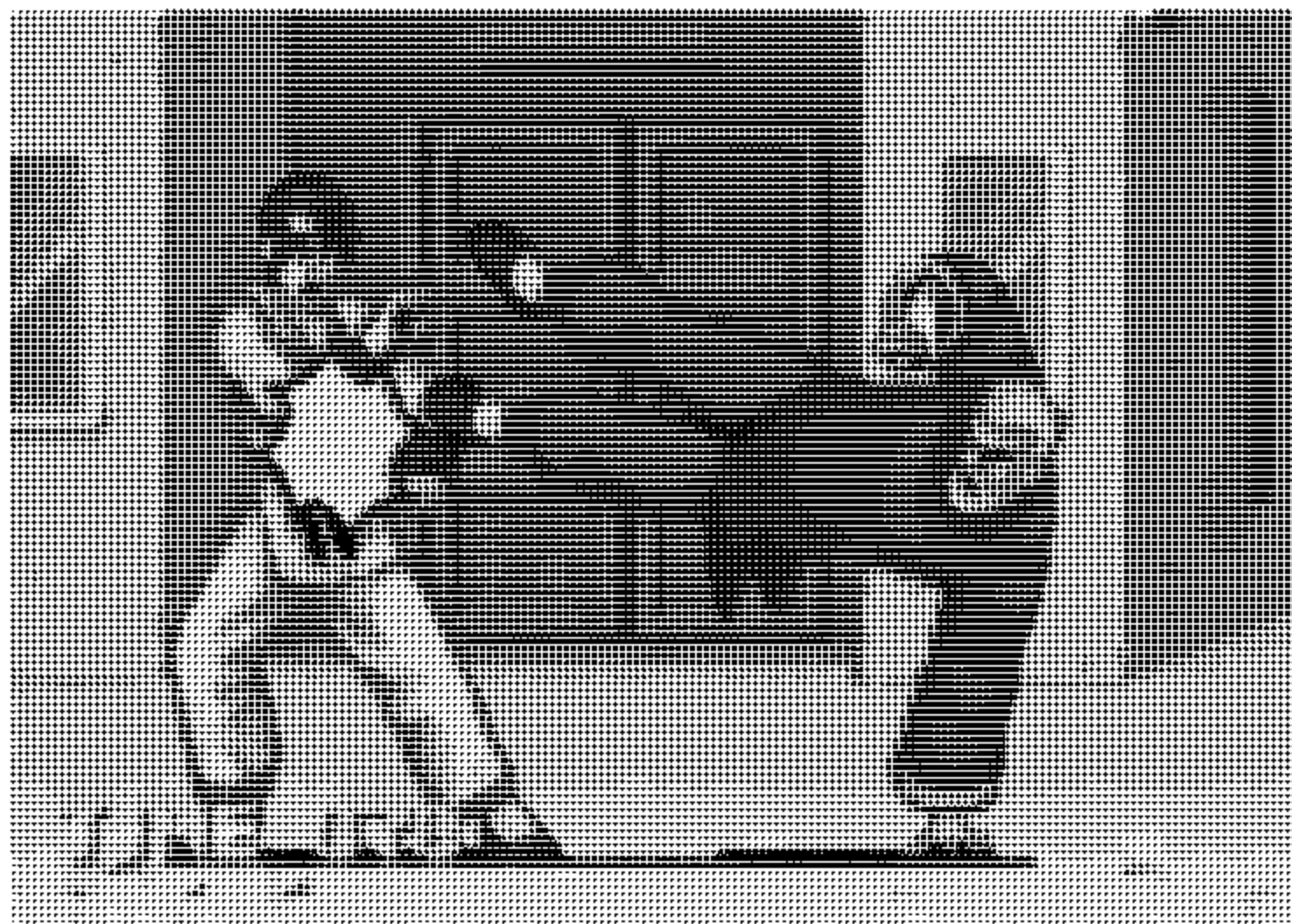
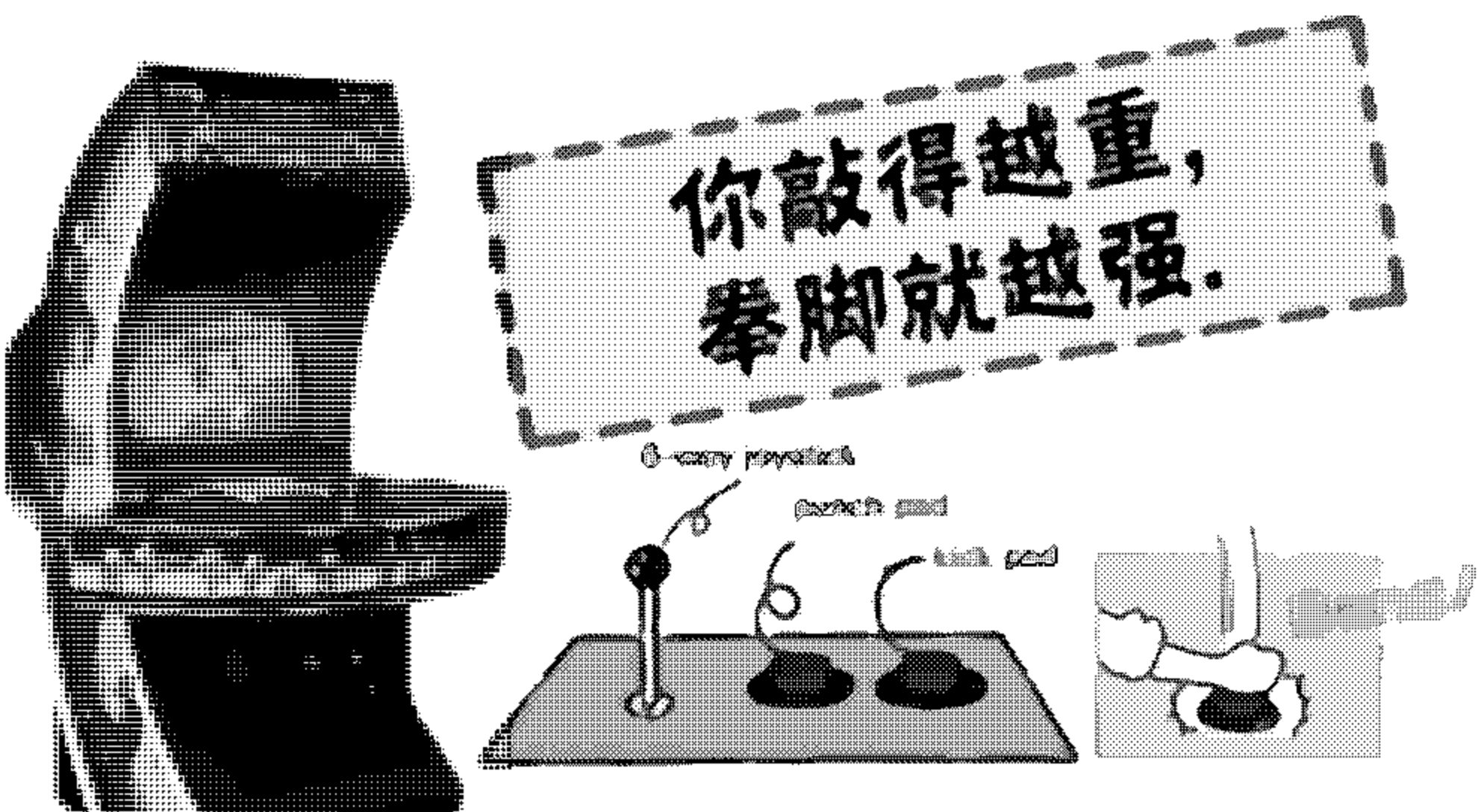
CAPCOM



有史以来
最令人兴奋的
专用机



ELECTROCOIN SALES



玩家用不同的力道敲击《街头霸王》的硕大按钮,来控制红发的隆:轻敲发出轻攻击,重敲引发强力一击。

the deal to create a *Street Fighter* cabinet for Capcom, he entrusted the job to a promising young Japanese-American industrial designer named Ken Hata.

Hata was born in California to an American father and a Japanese mother. His parents met in Japan, but moved to the United States on the theory it would be a better place to raise a family in the postwar years. However, three years after Hata was born, his mother dedded that the move had been a mistake, and the family relocated to Tokyo. Ken Hata stayed there through high school, then immediately returned to California to enroll at San Jose State University.

It was more than a decade later that his bilingual, bicultural pedigree helped land him the *Street Fighter* project—a six-week rush job that consisted of a long string of 12-hour days. It was challenging work, figuring out how to stuff all the pneumatic controls into a cabinet that also allowed two players enough room to use the large red and blue buttons. Hata devised an elegant solution: a crescent-shaped control panel that arched forward from the sides of the cabinet. He was pleased with the idea but skeptical that it would be accepted.

"When I was drawing it, I was thinking, 'They'll never go for this,'" Hata recalls. "It was deluxe, and we needed a cabinet that would be accepted by buyers. But I drew it anyway, to satisfy my ego. We were allowed to spend 5–10% of our time going wild, so that's what this was."

When his deluxe design was accepted, Hata was surprised and overjoyed.

哎唷!

One thing beyond Hata's control was the performance of the pressure-sensitive buttons. Capcom was handling that end, and its engineers worried during the design process that American players—forceful, blunt-instrument types, by the Japanese reckoning—would break the machines. The cabinets were constructed of thicker wood than was customary for Japanese arcade cabinets of the era, and the composition of the

buttons themselves was the subject of much discussion. When Hata finally got to play the finished game he realized it had a fatal flaw, despite its beautiful cabinet: "After playing awhile, you really got tired and your hands were all red."

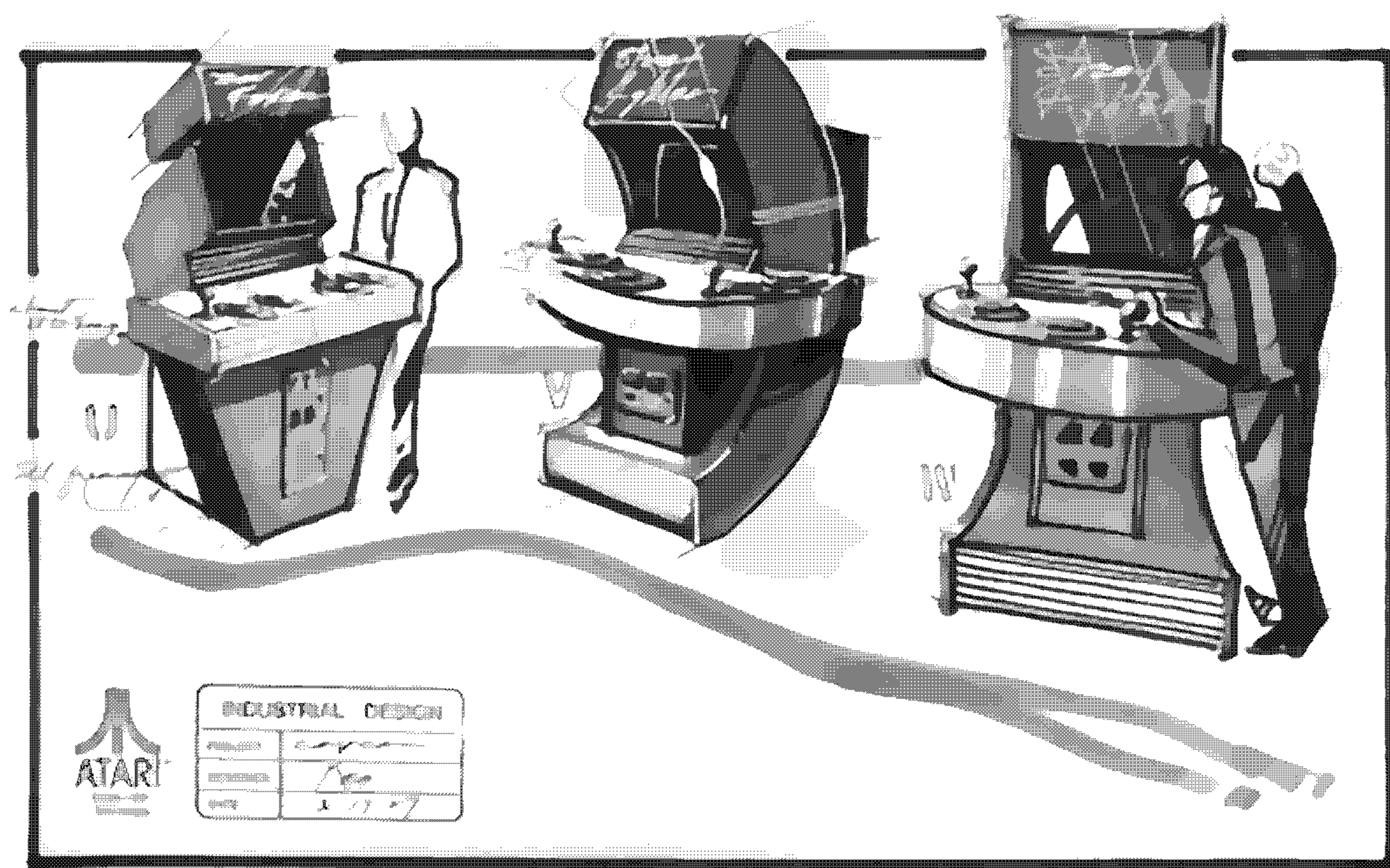
Players were hurting themselves, and hurting Hata's cabinets, too, as the pneumatic air tubes broke or disconnected from the buttons' pressure sensors. Capcom's promising new game was nearly knocked out on a technicality before the company sent out an upgrade kit that jettisoned the custom controls in favor of six discrete buttons. This setup would go on to establish a near-universal fighting-game convention, but the immediate result was to confirm the suspicions of Takashi Nishiyama, the game's co-creator. Arcade operators balked at the sight of all those buttons.

"I thought, 'Oh my God, this is going to be too complicated,'" says John Bailon, who managed a Southern California arcade. Bailon was worried the game would require extra maintenance, and would intimidate arcade-goers. He installed it anyway, and as the game began to gain popularity with players, he took notice.

"The players looked at it with a question mark at first. But then, gradually, the magic of the game started coming out, and the excitement just went to a new level," says Bailon. "We had to go back and buy multiple copies of the game, which was unheard of in those days."

Street Fighter's up-and-down legacy left Capcom's executives with a conundrum: their game had been a moderate success, but also demonstrated hit potential. The smart response was to make a sequel, but that, too, had suddenly become a complicated decision. That's because one day in 1988, Takashi Nishiyama and Hiroshi Matsumoto—*Street Fighter's* creators—announced they were leaving to join Capcom's crosstown rival in Osaka, Japan, game studio SNK Corp.

The *Street Fighter* sequel would require an all-new creative team.



玩了一会之后,你会非常疲劳,并且手上通红.

一肯·烟(美籍日裔),原版《街头霸王》机柜设计师

左图:肯·烟的《街头霸王》机柜方案;下图:(左)烟的设计成真了;(右)压力感应按钮近景.

后来卡普空发放了升级包,放弃了气动控制,代之以六个分离的按钮.





从观察到创新

安田朗的美国之行如何改变《街头霸王II》的开发重心

AKIRA NISHITANI STARTED HIS *Street Fighter II* planning process by evaluating the original *Street Fighter*. His first impressions weren't especially positive; he found the gameplay to be janky and difficult.

"That game wasn't really very good," says Nishitani.

Yet the first *Street Fighter* did have some striking things working in its favor. Those building blocks included its complex, six-button style of play, the "world warrior" format that featured characters with diverse fighting styles, and distinctive special moves like the fiery Hadoken.

What Nishitani didn't pick up on initially was the fun of head-to-head competition. It wasn't until he visited the United States for *Final Fight* location tests that he encountered the dynamic that would define his new game. There was a *Street Fighter* machine in the arcade where *Final Fight* was being tested, and Nishitani noticed people using—and loving—the two-player mode that he had considered more of a parlor trick than a core function.

"It wasn't very popular in Japan," says Nishitani. "Yet (Americans) seemed to enjoy it a lot, and it left a big impression on me."

As a result, Nishitani tweaked his vision for

Street Fighter II, and began planning to make player-versus-player competition its central emphasis. It was a defining moment for the series.

"Street Fighter games as we now know them are based on player-versus-player battles," says Akira Yasuda, Nishitani's *Street Fighter II* co-creator. "In the first game, it was a bonus feature. But *Street Fighter II* became a game that's more fun to play with others than by yourself."

Nishitani and Yasuda had already settled on a concept that would radically increase the complexity of *Street Fighter II*. They planned to give players eight different characters to choose from, each with a distinct fighting style and unique set of special moves. The appeal was twofold: it added layers of strategic depth to gameplay, and also gave players the opportunity to select the character with whom they most identified.

In the first *Street Fighter*, everyone played as Ryu, a Japanese karate master, unless a second player popped in a quarter. In that case, the newcomer suited up as Ken, an American karate master who was exactly like Ryu except for his coloring—Ken wore red and had blond hair. Players had to master just

one character, then learn to compete against the game's eight unique opponents. There was still a daunting combination of possible attacks and defensive moves to consider, but compared to learning eight characters inside and out—plus four additional non-playable villains that Nishitani added for good measure—it didn't even rate.

In *Street Fighter II*, the degree of difficulty didn't just increase, it multiplied. It was a huge risk, considering that the game's complex controls were already intimidating to players. It would be a game for serious gamers, but Nishitani had a notion that there was a market for a game like that. His target demographic was hardcore players just like him.

"I was the kind of person who would play with 100 yen [less than a dollar] for 12 hours a day. All the people around me were like that, too," he says.

The challenge of building the game was even more complex than learning to play. Nishitani had his hands full during development, but also had a growing sense that the game would work regardless. His partner Akira Yasuda created a rich animated world that ensured *Street Fighter II* was going to be fun.

《街头霸王II》的角色
通常一开始都只是个
粗线条的模式化形象。

疯狂的角色谱

Akira Yasuda and his team imagined characters that weren't just cool and tough, but also unique and fun—a combination that set *Street Fighter II* apart and captured players' imaginations around the world.

The *Street Fighter II* characters often started as broad-strokes stereotypes, such as a Russian wrestler and an American military hero. Yasuda then had a knack for fleshing them out in imaginative, exciting ways that made the characters memorable and unique. His Russian wrestler sported a mohawk, moved like a bear and struck like a tornado, for example, while the stern intensity and discipline of the American action hero was embodied in his improbably spiked blond hair. Yasuda repeated the process again and again, until he had crafted an entire roster of indelible characters.

Yasuda says starting with a stereotype is critical to his character creation process: "Maybe I'm a weird Japanese person, but I want to make something stereotyped—something exaggerated. To be perfectly honest, I think it's okay if they're discriminatory—not in an offensive way, but in a way that's easy to understand and fun."

There are two key ideas underpinning that philosophy. The first is that Yasuda believes in the power of contrast—of defining a world by populating it with a set of characters that aren't just diverse, but often polar opposites. That's easier to achieve if each character is clearly and quickly understood, both on its own terms and in relationship to its peers.

*Characters are relative things: if there are

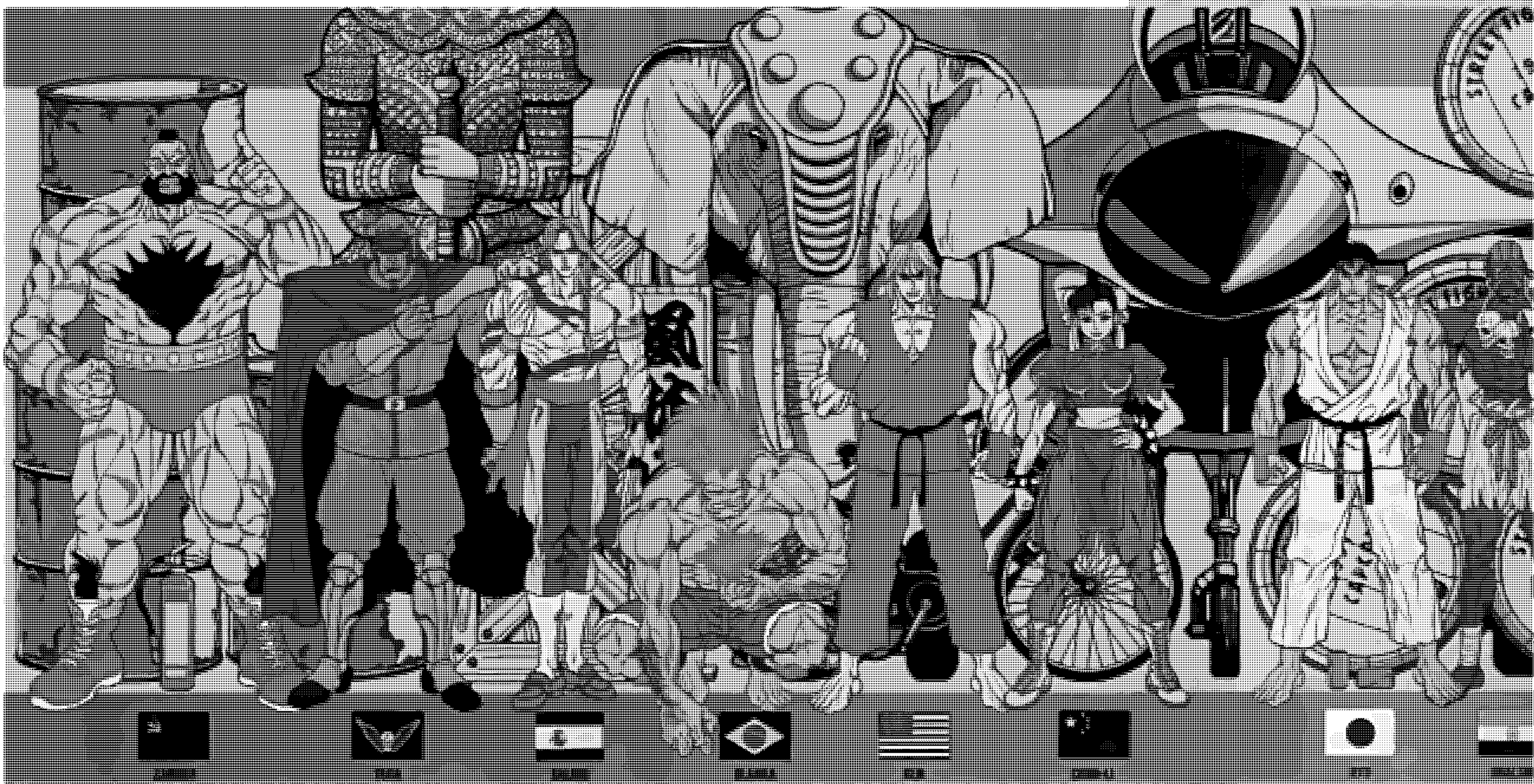
或许我是个古怪的日本人,但我想要做出些经典而又夸张的东西。

—安田朗,《街头霸王II》联合创始人



THE WORLD WARRIOR

上图:安田朗的《街头霸王II》街机版传单展现了他所有角色的怪异与多样。



上图:日本设定书《街头霸王II:完全资料》中列举的世界勇士们。

这不是一套英雄与女杰的塑料小人,而是风格多样的人物,各自都吸引到了一批忠心玩家与粉丝。

too many similar weird ones, for example, then weirdness becomes standard," says Yasuda. So in crafting the world of *Street Fighter II*, he sought to create characters who were instantly recognizable, amusingly unique, and different from one another—and whose inter-relationships were equally evocative.

The second idea behind Yasuda's embrace of stereotype is that he understood the power of getting people talking. He knew that playing with caricatures could help him do it.

"There's that Internet slang term, 'go viral'—in Japan, they also call it 'flaming up,'" says Yasuda. "Well, subconsciously, I was adding elements with the idea that they could go viral. I wanted a reaction, and perfect things don't instigate many reactions."

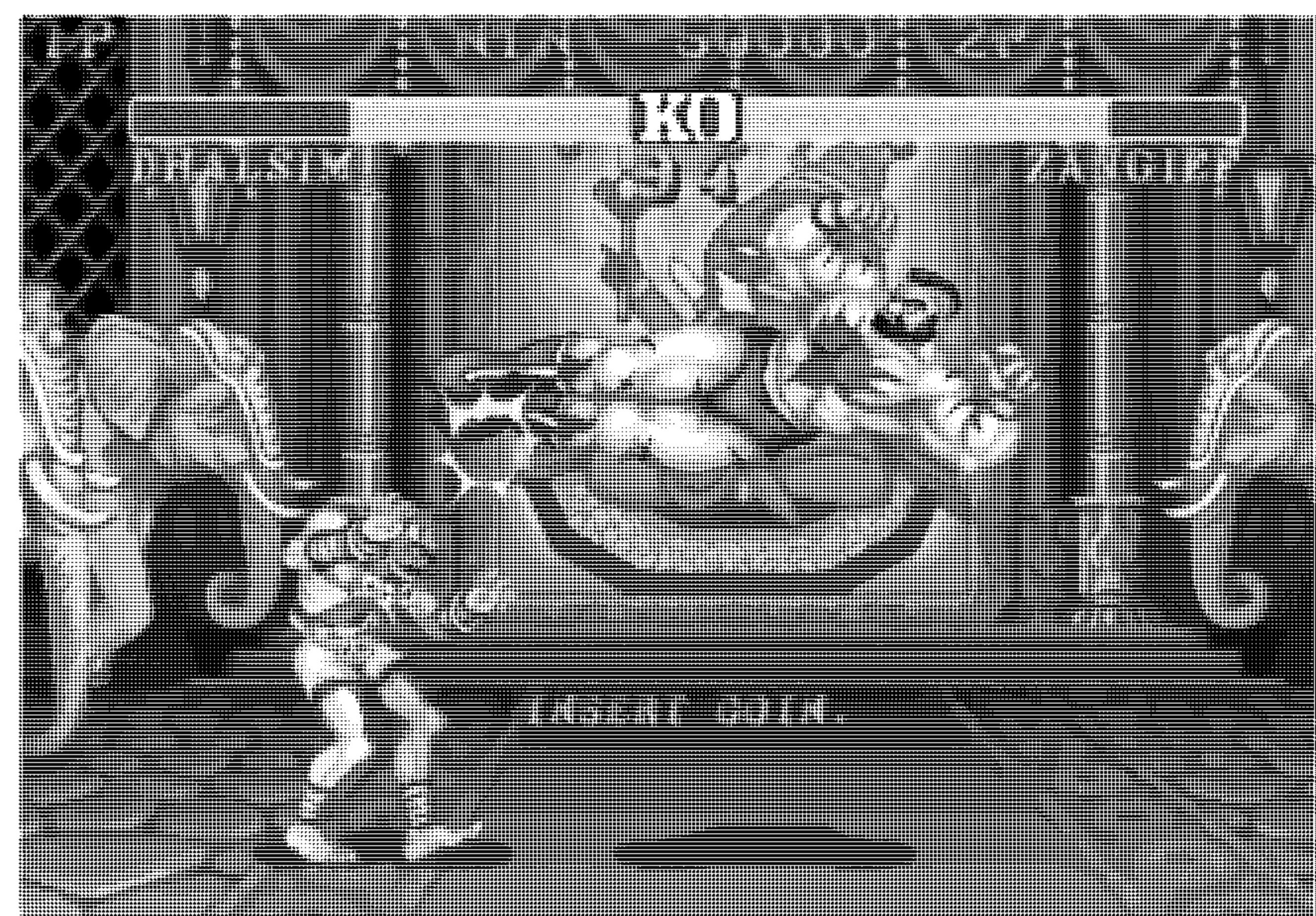
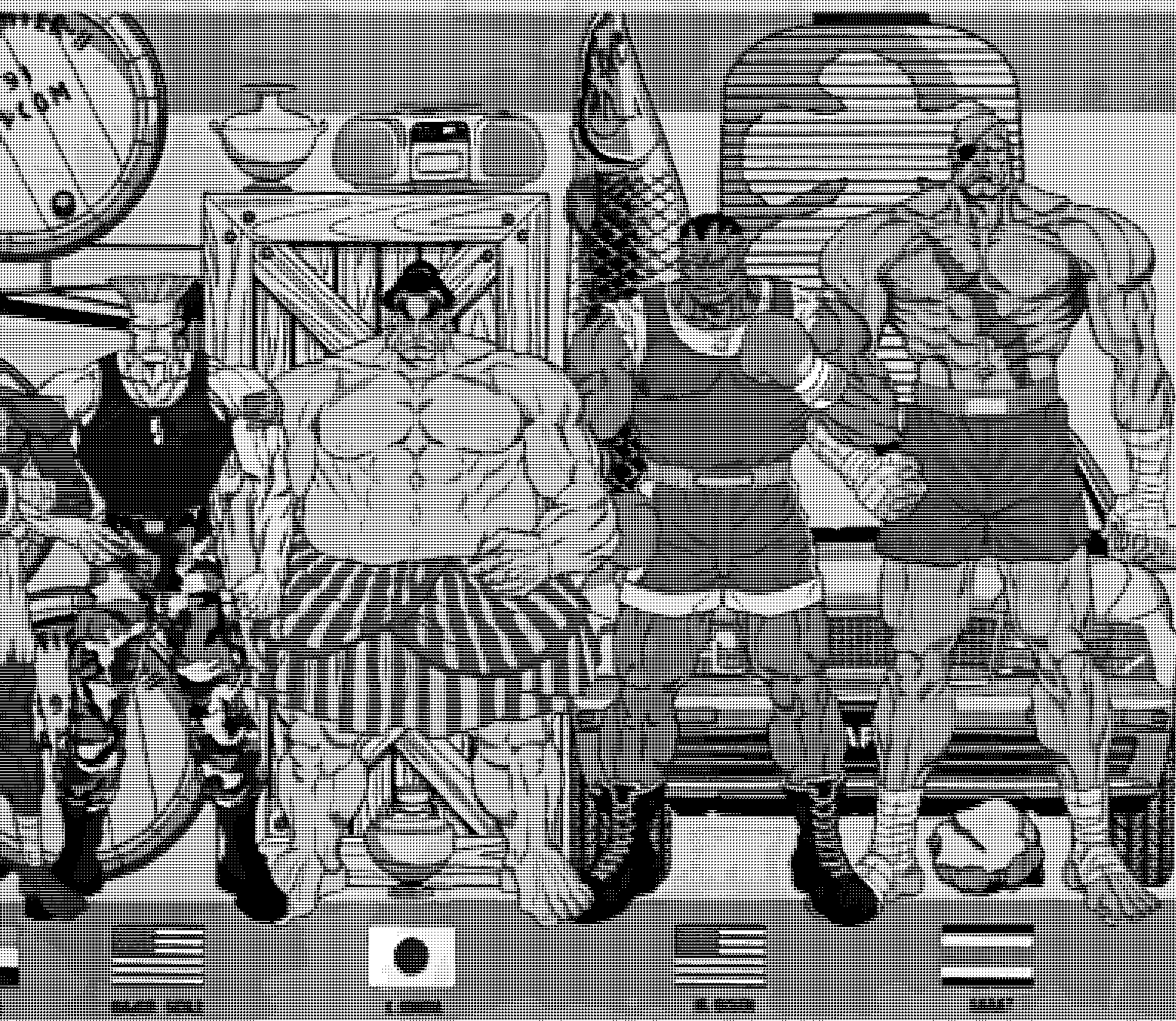
Out came Dhalsim, the yogi who could stretch his arms across the screen. Yasuda started with a stereotype, Indians and yoga, and built on it until he'd carried it to a ridiculous, memorable extreme. Then came E. Honda, a Japanese sumo wrestler who could hurtle through the air like a flabby bullet. He was "a character that I knew would create misunderstandings about Japan. And that's

exactly how I wanted to make him," Yasuda says. "I wanted the fat characters like Honda to come charging at you—for some reason I feel that fat characters have a duty to charge."

The whole world was Yasuda's canvas, inspiration and target, and every region got the same caricature-heavy treatment. *Street Fighter II*'s breadth made for a level playing field. (Brazilian feral man Blanka was an exception, as Yasuda followed an instinct that his game needed an animalistic character.)

The sociological merits of Yasuda's approach are perhaps debatable. The fruits of his labor are not: his cast of *Street Fighter II* characters captured the imaginations of players worldwide. This wasn't a plastic set of heroes and heels, but a diverse collection of avatars who each attracted a set of devoted players and fans.

The result of Nishitani's and Yasuda's combined labor was a game that was both brilliantly imagined and carefully balanced. When *Street Fighter II* hit arcades in 1991 and became an instant, global sensation, it did so by catering equally to lovers of competition, complexity and wacky self-expression.



下左:安田朗为《街头霸王II》超任版手册所画的插图;下右:《街头霸王II》游戏画面。





左至右:《街头霸王II:冠军版》广告;卡普空的詹姆斯·戈达德(中)正在评估街机的操作性;《超级街霸II:极速版》的投产广告。

迭代中的创新

卡普空借助一系列资料片的发布重新定义了其格斗游戏

DURING THE DEVELOPMENT PROCESS, Capcom founder Kenzo Tsujimoto discerned that his young team was building a hit. He traveled to California to make sure a corresponding sales operation was in place, summoning sales chief Bill Cravens to the Pan-Pacific Hotel in San Francisco. The veteran Cravens had just hired a young lieutenant named Jeff Walker to start the company's redemption-game division, and he brought Walker to the meeting.

But the conversation didn't go well, and by the time Cravens rose from his seat half an hour later, he was no longer a Capcom employee. Walker got up to leave, too, but Tsujimoto told him to sit down. Walker, uncertain, turned to Cravens.

Cravens gave his blessing, and Walker sat back down.

Tsujimoto leaned back, evaluating Walker for a moment before he spoke. "I have a new game coming," he said, "and I think it's going to be huge."

The smooth-talking, Porsche-driving Walker had moved to California from Illinois a couple years earlier, and already embodied

California chic. Tsujimoto, a lover of American culture who would ultimately retire to a Napa Valley winery, explained that he wanted a Hollywood feel for his new game's sales campaign. He said Walker, an up-and-coming star salesman, would be the guy to lead the charge.

"I won the lottery," recalls Walker.

Soon Walker had a *Street Fighter II* test machine on the ground in California. He called Japan in a panic.

"Six buttons!" Walker yelled into the phone. "Are you out of your mind?! These kids are never going to figure this out."

Walker, doing his unintentional best to cut up his winning lottery ticket, asked Capcom's Yoshiki Okamoto to cut back to two buttons. But Okamoto stood up for his team and his game, just as he often did when Tsujimoto stopped by to offer game-design advice. Walker was mollified.

Soon he was persuaded that *Street Fighter II* was everything Tsujimoto had promised. Walker installed a machine at Sunnyvale Golf and for field-testing, and its earnings blew away Walker's expectations. He added a

second machine, then a third, and the revenue per machine only increased. The original plan for the game was to sell it as a kit for arcade operators to drop into existing cabinets, but now Walker had become a believer. He raided the Capcom warehouse of 500 cabinets left over from the 1990 game *Merces*, and had them tricked out with a hyperactive, supersaturated purple-and-yellow design that was more '90s surf-shop than karate dojo.

"I was still so enamored with living in California, so I was going for that beach vibe with a reggae flavor," says Walker.

The cabinets sold in a heartbeat, and *Street Fighter II* mania was officially underway.

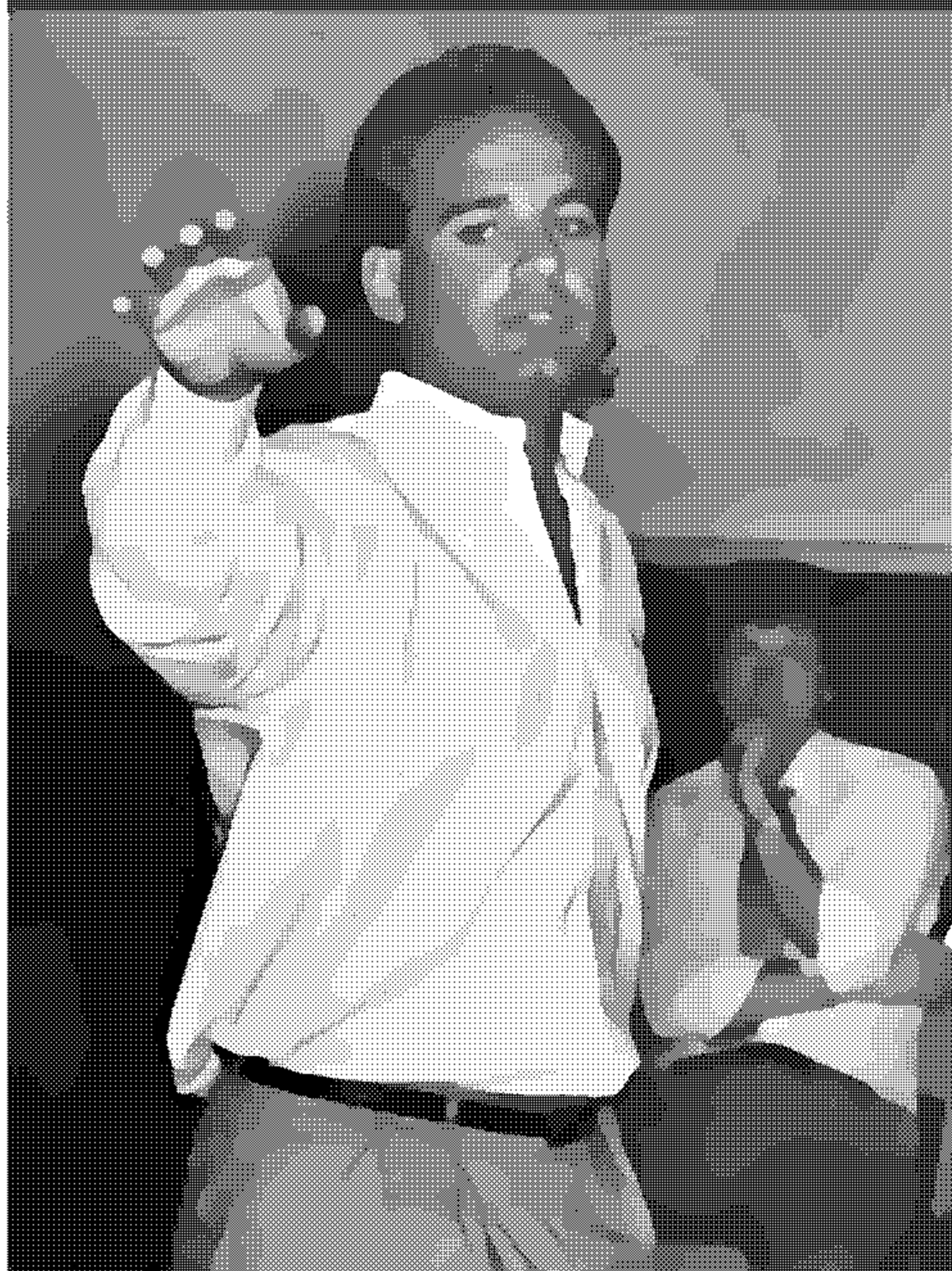
"The thing was a juggernaut," Walker says.

冠军级的第二次奋斗

By the fall of 1991, *Street Fighter II* was reaching the end of its lifecycle—at least according to the standards of normal games. But *Street Fighter II* was still building momentum in the arcades, and a tournament scene had even popped up, thanks in part to James Goddard, a young Capcom employee



卡普空接到了隆在空中放出波的报告——这本来是不可能的事情。



上图:《街头霸王II:极速版》的高速开发由船水纪孝(后排左)和詹姆斯·戈达德(后排右)所驱动;下图:卡普空《街头霸王II》的美国销售主管杰夫·沃克。

whom Walker had hired to represent the hardcore-gamer faction. (Walker, a casual player, didn't want to repeat his near-mistake over the six buttons.)

Goddard soon started pushing for a new version of the game where even the four bosses were playable, increasing the selectable-character count to 12. Walker, meanwhile, wanted players to be able to compete against one another using the same character.

Those requests were music to the ears of Akira Nishitani, who had kept tweaking his game even after its release.

"I never wanted to stop. The game was out, but I wasn't convinced we were done, so a programmer and I kept working on the game and creating new things," says Nishitani. But releasing multiple iterations of the same game wasn't common in those days, and to do a followup, he needed more than balance tweaks. He needed big, noticeable changes, and the requests from Walker and Goddard provided them.

The only thing standing in the way of a *Street Fighter II* followup was Tsujimoto—but his answer was no.

"It's done," he told Walker. Tsujimoto figured the game's next frontier was the home-console market, rather than arcades; he was already working on a version for the new and red-hot SNES, and Capcom was planning to release *Captain Commando* as its next arcade title. When Walker pushed, Tsujimoto asked him to assemble a meeting of Capcom's five largest distributors; Tsujimoto wanted a

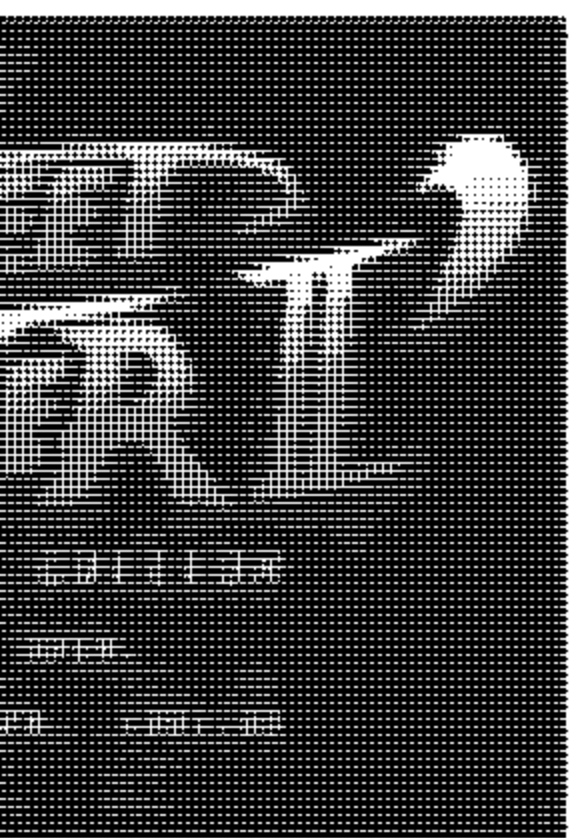
promise from the group to buy a thousand cabinets of the followup game—a staggering number for a risky second-generation version of an arcade game, especially considering it would be competing with the home-console version. But distributor Peter Betti quickly dispelled the drama when he began the meeting by announcing, "I'll take the first thousand. Meeting over. Okay, Kenzo, let's hit the golf course." Betti's peers bought another 2,000 copies at the meeting, and *Street Fighter II: Champion Edition* was born. It arrived in arcades in March of 1992.

游戏开发高速进行

Goddard was organizing tournaments and monitoring arcade play around the country, and was also traveling frequently to Japan, where Nishitani and Okamoto mentored him in the art of game design.

While he was stateside, he fielded occasional oddball calls from arcades. One day he received an especially bizarre report about Ryu throwing fireballs while airborne, which was not a move in either of Capcom's *Street Fighter II* games. He drove to Galaxy Arcade in San Jose to check it out, and sure enough, the wacky fireballs were real—and so was a new, wobbling Sonic Boom thrown by Guile, as well as a fireball for Kung-Fu master Chun-Li. The most striking feature of all was that the game had been sped up by about 30%.

It was the latest version of *Street Fighter II*—except it wasn't. This game, called *Street Fighter II: Rainbow Edition*, was a counterfeit



hack, and after playing a while, Goddard wasn't impressed. "It was trash. It was kind of fun and cool to see the crazy stuff, but the balance was completely destroyed."

There were two problems, however. First, *Rainbow Edition* wasn't a one-off hack; it was an unlicensed, mass-produced game that was quickly spreading to arcades worldwide. Second, when Goddard returned to the office late that afternoon and played *Champion Edition* with a friend, he noticed that his experience with *Street Fighter II* had been forever altered. "It was like I was underwater," he says. "It was painful to play."

Goddard had already drafted a *Rainbow Edition* report that minimized the threat of the illegal copycat game. Now he changed his tune: he believed Capcom needed to respond with its own sped-up version of *Street Fighter II*. Goddard spent the night at the office writing a new report—one that quickly convinced Tsujimoto, who asked him to sketch out a version of his proposed changes. While Walker fought the pirates distributing *Rainbow Edition*, Goddard raced to Japan, where he would work alongside Capcom's Japanese design team to produce the new version of the game.

Akira Nishitani was skeptical of Goddard's proposed changes. "I thought that the speed boost would spoil the gameplay," he says.

Still, Goddard knew Nishitani by then, and was confident they could work well together. Instead, however, he was introduced to a new partner upon arriving in Japan.

Nishitani had left the *Street Fighter* team after the release of *Champion Edition* to begin work on a similar Capcom fighting game with licensed characters called *X-Men: Children of the Atom*. He was still consulting on *Street Fighter*, but was traveling during the frantic rush to develop a response to *Rainbow Edition*. Goddard's new partner was Noritaka

上图:四部《街头霸王II》的资料片迅速地接连发布:1992年3月的冠军版,1992年12月的极速版—激战,1993年9月的《超级街头霸王II》,1994年2月的《超级街霸II:极速版》。

Funamizu, a Capcom staffer who had provided operational oversight to the *Street Fighter II* team during its initial development. Goddard pushed through his changes, but he did it despite a skeptical group of coworkers. In what was becoming a *Street Fighter* tradition, it wasn't until a Japanese location test of the sped-up *Street Fighter II* that Goddard won over Funamizu and his other colleagues.

"On the ride over, people were telling me not to be too disappointed with how this was going to go," Goddard recalls. "Then we got to the arcade and there were like 50 people crowded around this one machine, smiling and clapping."

That was the hard evidence that the Japanese team needed. Funamizu and Goddard worked together to craft and balance a new version of *Street Fighter II* that combined the speed and wackiness of *Rainbow Edition* with the fine balance of a genuine *Street Fighter* title. *Street Fighter II Turbo: Hyper Fighting* was developed in a six-week, hyper-speed sprint, and when it landed in December of 1992, Capcom had its third consecutive hit version of *Street Fighter II*.

Hyper Fighting interrupted Capcom's planned successor to *Champion Edition*, a version of the game called *Super Street Fighter II* that introduced four additional characters, including British spy Cammy. But Funamizu's resistance to the speed of *Rainbow Edition* persisted: *Super Street Fighter II*, released in late 1993, played at the speed of the earlier titles in the series, rather than the accelerated pace of *Hyper Fighting*. The result was the first flop in Capcom's *Street Fighter II* juggernaut, and one that Capcom would soon correct. *Super Street Fighter II Turbo*, released just a few months after *Super Street Fighter II*, sped up the game while retaining the new characters, and was a towering success. That game represents the pinnacle of *Street Fighter II*, and nearly a quarter century later it remains a favorite for fighting-game tournament play.

Ultimately, even Nishitani came around to the benefits of adding speed to the game. "When I tried it, I found it was really fun. The whole world was faster, and the higher speed meant more adrenaline and more excitement," he says.



上图:西村絹为《街头霸王II极速版—激战》绘制的插画,以游戏新加入的关键要素—春丽的气功波为重点。



上图:格斗玩家们参加加州斯坦顿传奇的南山区高尔夫兰公园街机赛;下图:Tomo Ohira(译注:首位街霸职业玩家,用取消来制造连续技而在南加州一战成名)于临近退役时在卡普空的策略视频中出场。

社区的杰出玩家们

早期南加州《街头霸王》明星玩家的大丰收

AS *STREET FIGHTER II* mania spread throughout America, debates raged about who among all the arcade champions was the greatest of the great. The fiercest, most bitter rivalry was between Northern and Southern California—especially after the famous champion of Los Angeles suddenly abdicated his throne.

By 1993, mustachioed Southern California teenager Tomo Ohira had established himself as the first undisputed King of *Street Fighter*. He was dominant in tournament play, the darling of game-strategy magazines, and a whispered legend in arcades across America. Humble pilgrims visited his home-turf *Street Fighter II* machine at a comic shop in Pico Rivera just to watch the grand master at work. He was the first *Street Fighter* superstar.

Then one day that summer, he walked away. Just a quiet poof—and suddenly the land had no king. Ohira would later say that his grueling training regimen had begun to hamper his grades and social life. It made no

sense to *Street Fighter II* devotees around the country, but that didn't matter. What mattered was that the throne was vacant. The proto-Internet erupted in chest-thumping taunts and supercilious claims—the Northern California crowd, especially, began to claim supremacy.

But Ohira's successor shared his Southern California stomping grounds.

Mike Watson grew up in Monterey Park, an inner-ring suburb of Los Angeles, and as a big and boisterous kid he played sports as often as he hit the arcade. His approach to competition was influenced by emerging NBA star Gary Payton, known for his trash-talking as much as his play. Watson copied Payton's schtick.

"You do anything you can to get into your opponent's head," he says. "*Street Fighter* is a mind game, just like chess, and whatever you can do to throw your opponent off, that's fair game—something to use to your advantage."

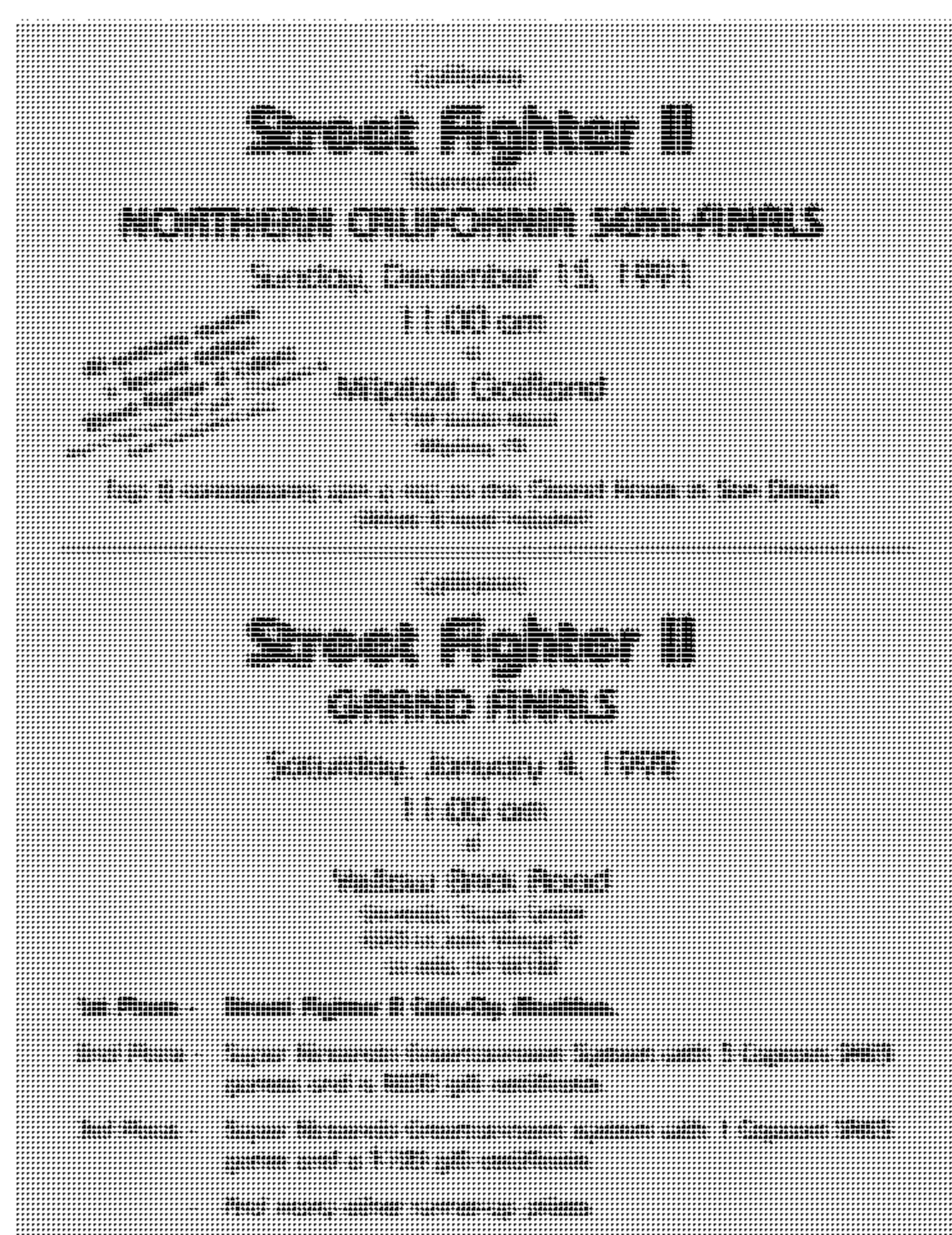
So when Watson started playing *Street Fighter II* shortly after the game's release in 1991, he looked for opportunities to break with

the game's emerging protocol. Throws, for example, were considered low-class in those days, and seldom employed by top players. "It was highly frowned upon—and so I was throwing people left and right," recalls Watson.

His next move was to stay quiet. Not out of shyness, but out of strategy and intensity.

"He had this thing where he would just look at you, and try to intimidate you right from the get-go with this glare he had," remembers Southern California arcade operator John Ballon.

Even if Watson was itching to run his mouth like Gary Payton, he refrained in order to preserve his secret-weapon: Cantonese. Watson looked white or maybe Latino, but was in fact half-Chinese, and spoke fluent Cantonese. Chinese players abounded at the arcades near his house, and as a young teen, Watson would play dumb while his older opponents insulted him in their native tongue. Once he'd beaten them, he'd turn casually and say, in perfect Cantonese, "Hey, let's go



左图:早期加州《街头霸王II》锦标赛的宣传单;上图:南山区高尔夫兰公园街机厅。

again, and this time, why don't we play for your girlfriend?"

There were fights—lots of them. Watson was a 15-year-old kid who was taking on older guys who took their *Street Fighter* seriously. Once he'd added insult to injury with his little taunt, a few of them wanted to respond with some injury of their own.

"That would just start the fireworks. I mean, if you're like 20 years old and you've got some hot girl with you, you don't want to get your butt kicked by a 15-year-old, especially if he's talking smack and trying to show you up," Watson says.

When the situation escalated in the parking lot outside the arcade, Watson would deploy his other secret weapon: a really large friend and fellow *Street Fighter* player named Martin Vega. "I wouldn't say I was hiding behind him, but I always knew I had this brick wall behind me in case anything really went down," Watson recalls.

Watson entered his first tournament in 1992, playing *Street Fighter II: Champion*

Edition, and earned instant attention. After advancing through the losers bracket to face Tomo Ohira in the final, he beat Ohira—one of Ohira's only lost matches, ever. Of course, as the loser's bracket champion, Watson needed to beat Ohira *again* in order to win the tournament, and he fell short in the rematch. But his second-place finish and competitive showing against Ohira had marked him as a player to watch.

Over the following two years, as Watson improved and Ohira faded into memory, Watson ascended to the throne. He was masterful at the final iteration of *Street Fighter*, *Super Street Fighter II Turbo*. He was still in high school, but suddenly also a celebrity featured in *GamePro* magazine. His fellow Southern Californians were so keen to represent on the national stage that one of them sponsored his entry in a two-day, 256-player tournament near Chicago in 1994. He won it. "That was my first taste of notoriety. My friends at school saw me on the newsstand,

and it was like, 'Whoa, that's so awesome,'" remembers Watson. The attention and success fueled his desire to play, and the following summer he turned his attention to the newest title in the series, *Street Fighter Alpha: Warriors' Dreams*. Around the same time, a Vietnamese friend told him about a promising young Latino player who lived nearby.

"I was like, 'There is no Latino guy who is good at *Street Fighter*.' Like, give me a break—only the Asians were winning," remembers Watson. But to humor his friend, he traveled down to a shopping-center arcade at the corner of Beach Boulevard and Warner Avenue in Huntington Beach. He met the kid, named Alex Valle, and they played *Street Fighter Alpha*.

Watson didn't immediately get the sense that he'd met someone destined to join him and Tomo Ohira in the pantheon of great Southern California champions.

"Actually," remembers Watson, "I worked him pretty good."



上图:"Daichan"绘制的《街头霸王α》封面图;右图:"Bengus"为α和α2绘制的插图.



上图:"Daichan"绘制的《街头霸王α》
插画;右图:α、α2、α3的游戏画面。



后续计划

卡普空在《街头霸王II》后的两步走战略

AS THE WILDLY SUCCESSFUL, four-year reign of *Street Fighter II* gradually wound to a close, Capcom's leaders had to settle on a followup—or several. Their 1991 release had popularized a new genre, but now the market was flooded with fighting games: *Mortal Kombat*, *Tekken* and *Virtua Fighter* had been released during *Street Fighter II*'s long run, while rival Osaka studio SNK had launched three distinct series of fighting games over the same period.

Emerging technology helped to enable Capcom's competitors, because *Street Fighter*'s animation was hard to match. *Street Fighter II* "was so beautiful, and so much better than anything out there in terms of drawn artwork for video games," says *Mortal Kombat* art director Josh Tsui. But the *Mortal Kombat* team found a different way, creating fighting

games using motion-capture video of real-world martial artists. *Virtua Fighter*, meanwhile, used three-dimensional, polygon-based animated characters. Capcom battled back by doubling down on its animated strong suit, and by producing fighting games in astonishing quantity.

Capcom had gained a reputation as slow-moving for milking its *Street Fighter II* mega-hit for four years. But when the company decided to change gears, it did so dramatically, cranking out so many lavishly animated fighting games that it was difficult for players to keep track of them all.

There was *Darkstalkers: The Night Warriors* (1994), which ran on the same engine as *Street Fighter II* but featured new characters. There was *X-Men: Children of the Atom* (1994), a game that *Street Fighter II* creators Akira

Nishitani and Akira Yasuda worked on, and which led to a long-running series of fighting games that pitted Marvel heroes against *Street Fighter* characters. (The latest, *Marvel vs. Capcom: Infinite*, was scheduled to be released in fall 2017.) There were Capcom fighting games featuring schoolgirls, vampires, pro wrestlers and mutants, until just about every sort of character imaginable had been shuffled onto a colorful stage and forced to engage in animated hand-to-hand combat.

That list of Capcom fighting games doesn't even include the hit series that started the fighting-game craze. There was plenty of action in the *Street Fighter* universe, too, as the middle and late '90s saw three distinct *Street Fighter* series in development: multiple games were released under the *Street Fighter Alpha*, *Street Fighter III* and *Street Fighter EX*

banners, not to mention 1995's outlier *Street Fighter: The Movie* game, or *Super Puzzle Fighter II Turbo*, a 1996 puzzle game starring the series' characters.

The EX games were developed by Akira Nishitani after he left Capcom in 1995 to form his own studio, Arika. The polygon-based fighting games he created there were released under the Street Fighter banner thanks to a deal with Nishitani's old boss, Yoshiki Okamoto, but are set in a different universe with mostly different characters—and thus beyond the scope of this book.

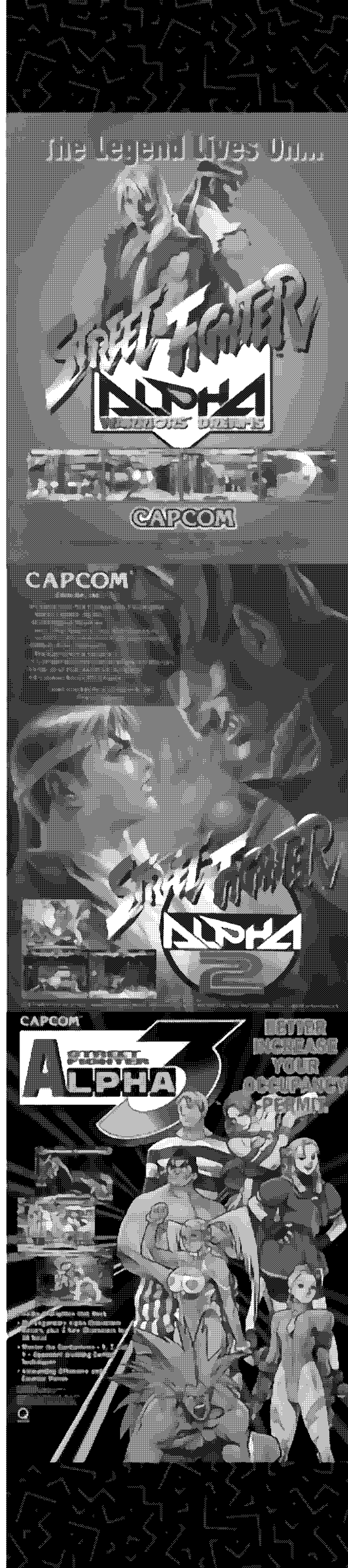
Street Fighter Alpha and *Street Fighter III* are a different story. Those were the series on which Capcom staked its Street Fighter legacy.

街头霸王的前传

Street Fighter III was to be the genuine heir to *Street Fighter II*—the game that would usher in the next generation of fighters, much as its predecessor had done. But in order to fulfill that potential, the game had to wait on the arrival of Capcom's third-generation arcade system board. The new hardware boasted a faster processor, better graphics and better sound compared to the second-generation board, which had debuted in 1993 with *Super Street Fighter II*. It was going to be killer, but wasn't quite ready, which meant the *Street Fighter Alpha* team had the first crack at carrying the mantle of *Street Fighter II*.

Alpha (called *Street Fighter Zero* in Japan) was conceived as a game that would fill in the story gaps between the original *Street Fighter* and *Street Fighter II*. Capcom manager Noritaka Funamizu tapped Hideaki Itsuno, a newcomer to the company, to helm the game. The idea was for a crew of young artists and developers to offer a fresh take on an earlier version of the Street Fighter universe, one in which characters such as Ryu and Ken were more youthful than they appeared in *Street Fighter II*. Itsuno's team was also tasked with a bit of Capcom housecleaning: while *Street Fighter III* was awaiting the third-generation arcade system board, *Street Fighter Alpha* had to be built to run on both the first and second generation boards in order to help Capcom clear out its inventory of first-generation hardware.

Street Fighter Alpha's artistic direction veered away from Akira Yasuda's *Street*



Fighter II playfulness, as well as from the hybrid Japanese-meets-western drawing style that helped characterize *Street Fighter II*. The look of *Street Fighter Alpha* was very Japanese and anime-inspired—a look that was rapidly gaining traction in the West, but that markedly changed the style of the series.

The character roster played to its prequel roots by including characters from the original *Street Fighter* as well as from *Final Fight*, along with a few *Street Fighter II* stalwarts and a cleverly conceived character named Charlie Nash—a war buddy whom Guile had aimed to avenge in *Street Fighter II*.

But when *Street Fighter Alpha: Warriors' Dreams* was released in the summer of 1995, it ran into two problems. First, competitive players found the gameplay to be janky. These were seasoned *Street Fighter II* players who were looking for an update to their beloved (and carefully dissected) favorite game, and the notion that *Alpha* might represent a step backward was a shock to them. Second, even though Capcom employees knew that *Street Fighter III* was supposed to be the real sequel, nobody told the players.

"When *Alpha* first came out, it was the first time we were getting a new Street Fighter game that wasn't *Street Fighter II*," recalls fighting-games commentator James Chen. "There was a lot of excitement because of that. But *Alpha* turned out to be kind of a busted game in terms of balance, and the characters didn't feel fleshed out."

For Capcom, this was a crisis moment akin to the indifference that had greeted *Super Street Fighter II* in 1993. Back then, the response was to rush a better game to market on the quick, *Super Street Fighter II Turbo*. Itsuno followed the same script with *Street Fighter Alpha 2*, with similar success. His team scrambled to address the balance and gameplay issues, scrapping the prescribed "chain combos" from *Alpha* and replacing them with more *Street Fighter II*-like "custom combos." And in order to recapture more of the magic of the *Street Fighter II* roster, the *Alpha* team approached the man who had created *Street Fighter II*'s characters, Akira Yasuda.

But in Yasuda, they found an artist who wasn't particularly impressed with their work.

"I didn't like [*Alpha*] because it felt like they wanted only characters who were cool

"Bengus"的插画,以樱卓然于《街头霸王II》众为特色.这个《街头霸王》的老牌画师很喜欢樱,他说:"樱自然就能跳进我的脑海.我感觉画她时很轻松,我的意思是同画隆或者春丽时相比."



《街头霸王α2》在1996年2月首度登场时,樱曾轰动一时。

and stylish by the standards of the time. They wanted to make a game without any so-called 'weird' characters, like the Sumo fighter Honda—characters that these employees who were younger than me called 'uncool,'" Yasuda recalls. "I also didn't like that they were just using the old characters [such as Ryu and Ken] without changing their techniques or anything, just making them a bit more anime-style. It felt too easy and too convenient—and like there wasn't enough new content offered to the players."

Itsuno and the *Alpha* team already were smarting, and now they were getting a lecture from one of the godfathers of *Street Fighter II*. He'd created most of the characters in their

game—those from *Final Fight* as well as from *Street Fighter II*. But they had come to ask for a new character, and they eagerly awaited Yasuda's fearsome new warrior.

Soon they had their answer: a spunky schoolgirl named Sakura.

"I know what they wanted," says Yasuda. "They wanted someone cool, like a character from *The Matrix*. But I made a character that I expected the leaders of the project to dislike."

He looked at the creation of Sakura as a teachable moment, a chance to demonstrate the power of contrast to less experienced character designers and planners. "She was a character outside the game's narrow world view, a girl in a sailor uniform, someone who

wasn't stylish. She was interesting because she was so different—the sort of character that *Alpha* and the older *Street Fighter* games didn't have."

When *Street Fighter Alpha 2* arrived at arcades in February 1996—just nine months after the release of its predecessor—Sakura was an instant hit, vaulting into the pantheon of *Street Fighter* favorites alongside many of Yasuda's *Street Fighter II* creations. The balance issues were likewise resolved, and *Alpha 2* began to look the part of a genuine *Street Fighter* sequel. The game, along with *Street Fighter Alpha 3* in 1998, would go on to capture the imaginations of the best *Street Fighter* players in the world.



崔和巴列都曾是人。

——杰森·威尔森，中心部锦标赛组织者



上图:枝木真也为《街头霸王α3》PS版所绘制的插画;左图:1998年艾利克斯·巴列(Alex Valle,左)首次遭遇梅原大吾(右),自那之后他们多次交手。

游戏职业选手的诞生

旧金山的第一次《街头霸王》职业玩家碰撞

GRAINY VHS TAPES OF the Valle-Choi matchup at Golfland soon became coveted items, copied and mailed around the country. The Street Fighter newsgroup pulsed with tales of their epic tilt. The two stars began crisscrossing the country to appear at tournaments.

"Choi and Valle were celebrities," recalls Midwestern tournament organizer Jason Wilson. "Chicago had good players, but we wanted the West Coast guys."

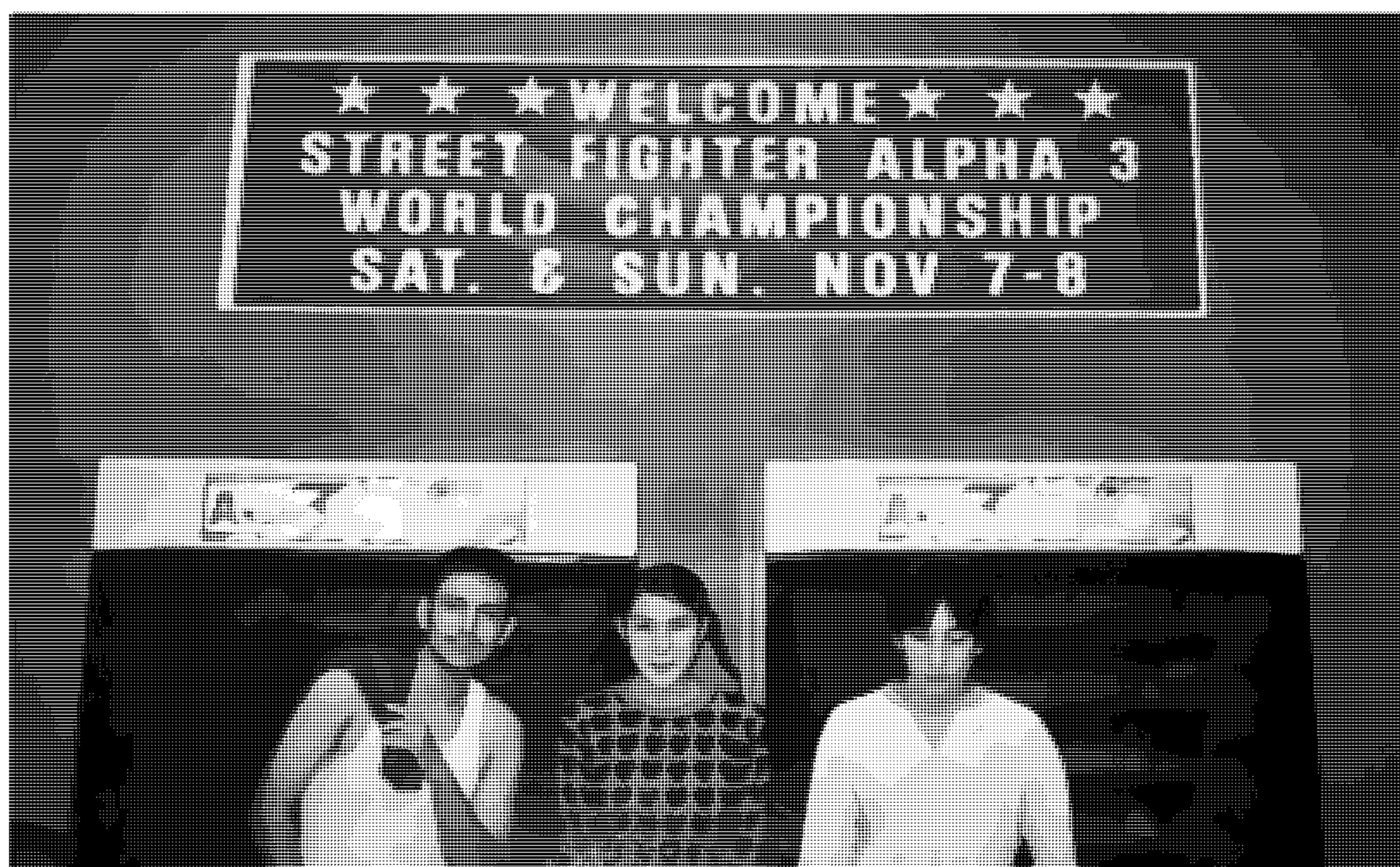
Their notoriety marked the beginning of pro gaming. And it quickly became an international phenomenon when young Japanese champion Diogo Umehara announced he was traveling to San Francisco to compete in a 1998 *Street Fighter Alpha 3* tournament.

Umehara cruised to the finals. There he met Valle, whose aggressive, unpredictable style gave him fits.

"The Japanese played more logically, more technique-focused, and I was at the forefront of that style," Umehara recalls. "But Alex played more forcefully, more wildly, and made me realize that technical play alone wasn't good enough." Unfortunately for Valle, Umehara proved to be a quick study. The Japanese star adapted and won the tournament.

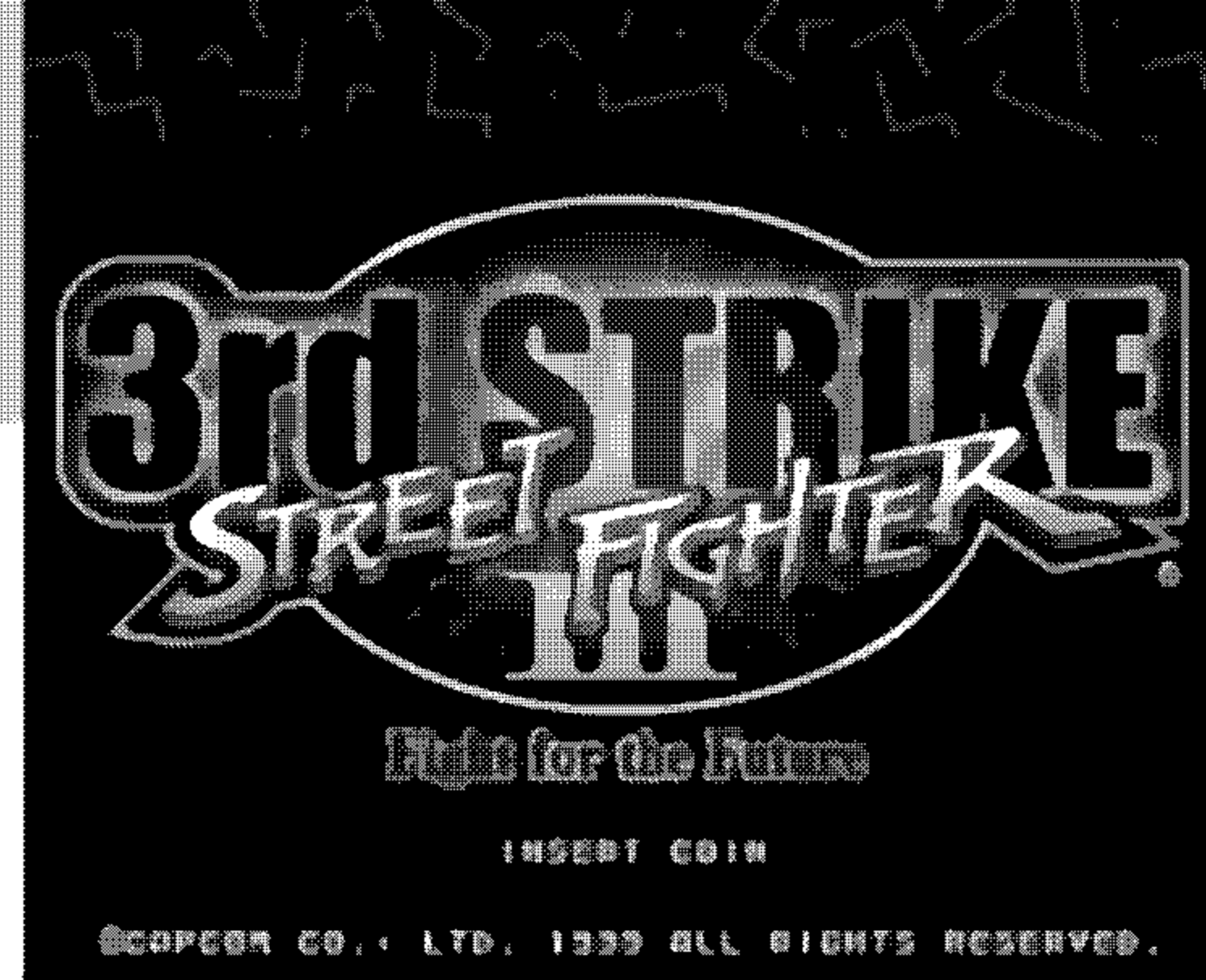
Still, the event marked the beginning of a nascent rivalry that could have kickstarted a global following.

But what Street Fighter's players and fans didn't know was that Capcom would soon wind down its fighting-game factory, robbing the competitive-game community of much of its momentum. Umehara ruled a kingdom in decline.



上图:《街头霸王》爱好者们(注:后排中间是卡普空特别格斗顾问塞斯·基利安);右图:艾利克斯·巴列与梅原大吾在为1998年的比赛做准备。

右图:1999年《街头霸王III:第3次冲击》街机画面;下图:《街头霸王III:新生代》介绍角色阿历克斯的广告(西村绢绘)。



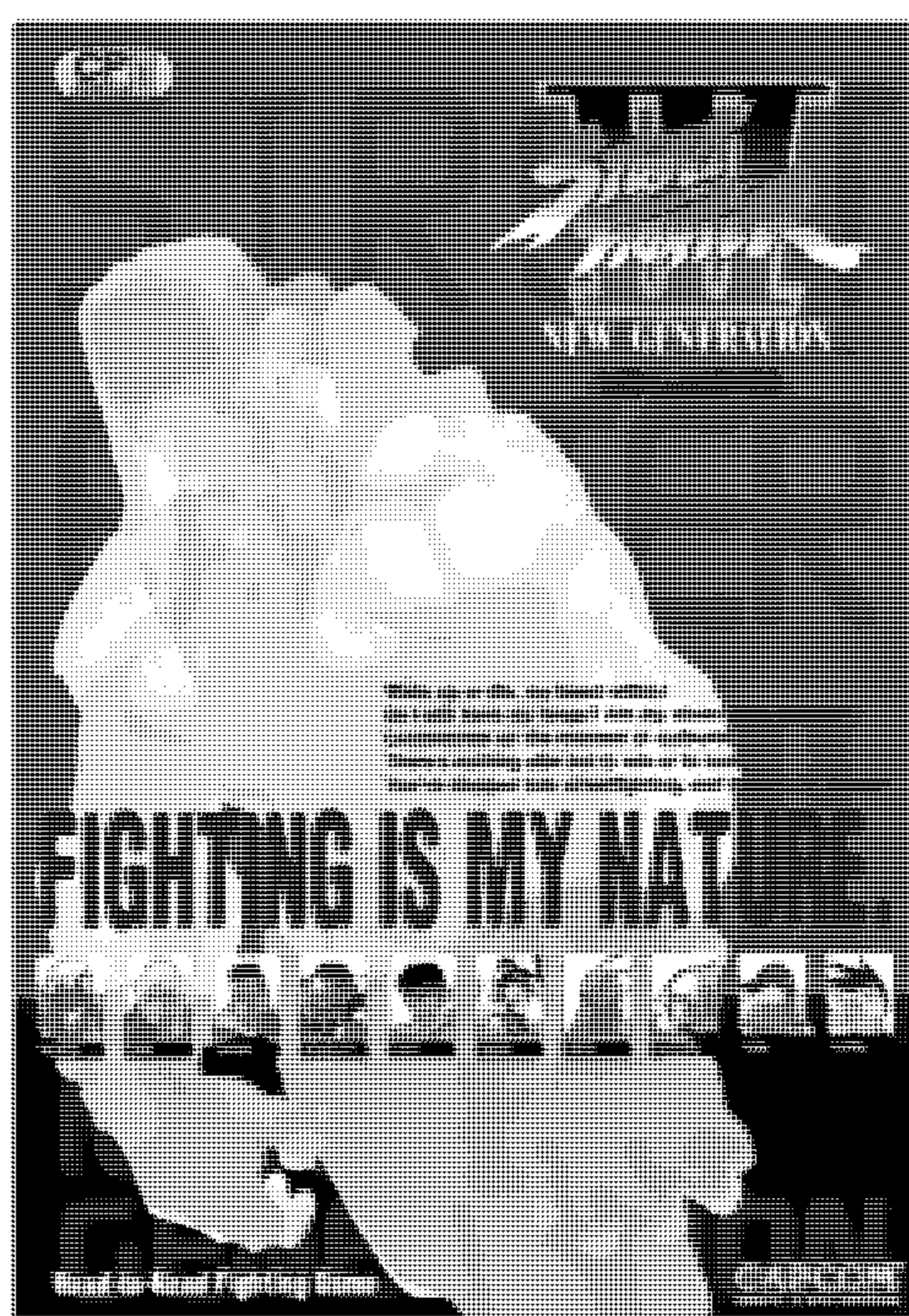
失策的好游戏

《街头霸王III》本来可以成为经典,但这并没有发生

EVEN AS AKIRA YASUDA was giving *Street Fighter Alpha 2* a boost with the new character Sakura, he was also working on a next-generation fighting game with a wacky and diverse cast of characters befitting his legacy. He wasn't initially envisioning that the game would become *Street Fighter III*, but as the project developed, it made sense—it had a talented team, led by producer Tomoshi Sadamoto, some *Street Fighter II* DNA, in the form of Yasuda, and an ambitious graphical plan that would take full advantage of Capcom's third-generation arcade system board.

Three iterations were released, beginning with *Street Fighter III: New Generation* in 1997, and culminating in *Street Fighter III: 3rd Strike* in 1999. But none of them managed to connect with a mass audience the way that *Street Fighter II* or even the *Street Fighter Alpha* games had. From a business perspective, the series was a major failure—especially given Capcom's understanding that *Street Fighter III* was the true heir to *Street Fighter II*. The two chief factors behind the games' lack of success are inter-related: fighting-game fatigue, and a radically new cast of characters.

Street Fighter II had broken through in 1991 thanks to a slew of innovations: not only did the game feature a cast of interesting, imaginative characters, but it ushered in the era of head-to-head gameplay and massive strategic complexity. By 1997, gamers had an abundance of complicated fighting games to choose from, and they also had seen a host of quirky animated pugilists, as artists at game studios around the world tried to replicate Yasuda's formula. It was simply harder to break through with an all-new fighting game than it had been six years earlier, even with the *Street Fighter* brand name and holdover



休闲玩家不认识新角色,而人们还没有准备好接受它(的改变)。

—麦克博士,(芝加哥)“疾驰鬼魂”街机厅

characters you did not.

Yasuda knew that. He also loved the new game he was helping to create, and thought the *Street Fighter* name might turn it into a hit.

"The [Capcom] fighting games beyond *Street Fighter* just wouldn't sell. The way it

felt at the time was that these projects would either turn into a *Street Fighter* game or disappear," he recalls.

Yet *Street Fighter III* didn't make much of an impact on players even with its pedigreed title. The game may have benefited from a next-generation arcade system board, but players didn't sense that it heralded a new era of fighting games.

The curious thing, however, is that a lot of serious fighting gamers are ardent in their affection for *Street Fighter III*, and particularly for its final iteration, *Street Fighter III: 3rd Strike*. For a major commercial flop, the game has a lot of knowledgeable, passionate fans.

"That series was so well-crafted from a game-design standpoint," says Doc Mack, owner of the Galloping Ghost Arcade in suburban Chicago, the world's largest arcade. "Higher-caliber players recognized it right away. I still remember the first time I played it in an arcade, and it was phenomenal. But by the time I went back, it was already gone. Casual players didn't recognize the characters, and people just weren't ready for what it was. Casual gamers needed to be shown why this game was so good, and had that happened—especially with *3rd Strike*—I think the whole arcade industry would be different."

Instead, the game sold poorly. And arcades, which had been in decline prior to the *Street Fighter II*-instigated player-versus-player craze, resumed their slide.

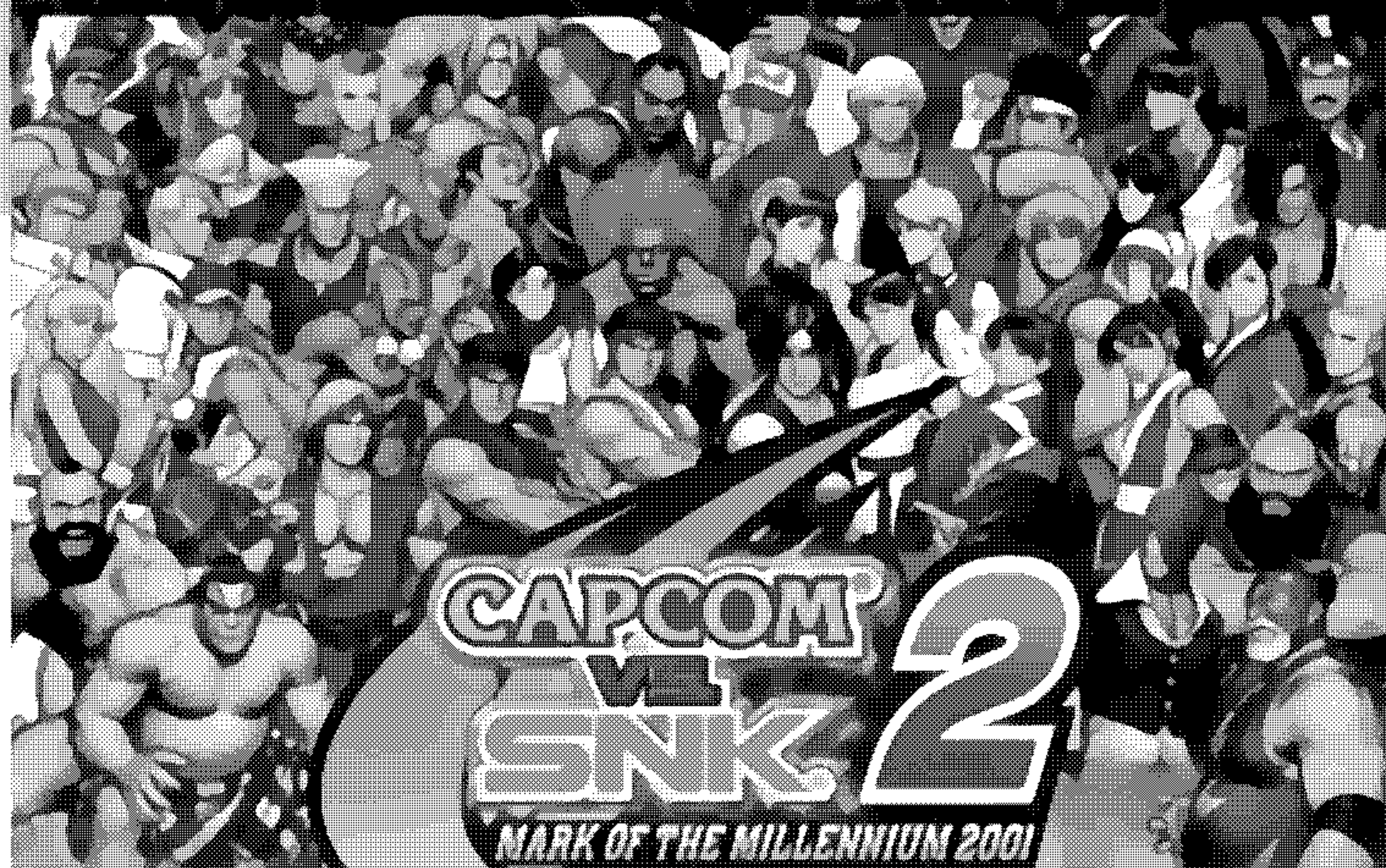
The *Street Fighter* series went dormant after *3rd Strike*, except for a trickle of crossovers that brought the characters back to their roots: Capcom produced two games pitting the *Street Fighter* warriors against the fighters from Capcom's crosstown rival in Osaka, the game studio SNK.



KING OF THE ARCADE



这些《卡普空对SNK》的复合插画以多名画师的合作为特色。两作角色都有不少空手道大师,但SNK没有对应布兰卡或E.本田的角色。



这次合作是跨区域对立双方的一次性和解,也一次性为两个公司数十年之久的“飞速制作格斗游戏”之争划下了句点。

大阪效应

卡普空与SNK数十年之久的跨区域对立终于以合作结束了

WHEN FIGHTING GAMES EMERGED as a global pop-culture phenomenon in the '90s, it was a curiosity that two of the genre's primary purveyors, Capcom and SNK, both hailed from Osaka.

Tokyo and Osaka are the informal capitals of Japan's two largest metropolitan areas, with Tokyo in the center of the country and Osaka about three hours southwest as the Shinkansen bullet-train flies. They're both giant cities, but that's not to say they're the same place. Tokyo buzzes with the energy of a global cultural and political center, while Osaka has a somewhat more regional, working-class feel. And in Osaka, people tend not to take themselves quite as seriously as their Tokyo counterparts. "Osaka people are always trying to make a joke," says *Street Fighter II* co-creator Akira Nishitani, a Tokyo native. "There's an expectation that you either need to surprise someone or make them laugh at least once a day."

That value seeped into the *Street Fighter* games, which navigate a fine line between playfulness and fearsomeness. But it didn't cross the Katsukawa River into the northern Osaka suburb of Suita, where Capcom's rival studio SNK is based. SNK's fighting-game characters exude cool, rather than the zaniness that frequently permeates *Street Fighter*.

SNK's head-to-head fighters, beginning with 1991's *Fatal Fury*, were spearheaded by Takashi Nishiyama—the co-creator of the original (and relatively straight-laced) *Street Fighter*. Nishiyama had a vision for fighting games that was quite distinct from his *Street Fighter* successors at Capcom, Nishitani and Akira Yasuda. That signature difference in tone, along with a heavy dose of employee crossover, contributed to a decade-long rivalry between the two fighting-game makers.

"We were like blood relatives who didn't get along," recalls Yoshinori Ono, who worked as a

sound designer on *Street Fighter III* and is now the *Street Fighter* series producer.

The ice began to thaw in the late 1990s, as fighting games overall were declining in popularity, which put the companies' decade-long rivalry in a new light. They agreed to a deal in which each company would produce two games pitting their own fighting-game characters against those from the other company. The arrangement produced one standout, *Capcom vs. SNK 2: Mark of the Millennium 2001*.

The collaboration was one-part truce between crosstown rivals, and one part coda to a decade-long run in which the two companies had cranked out fighting games at a furious pace. It was also, perhaps, an acknowledgment from Capcom that the fighting-game era was drawing to a close. The company mothballed its *Street Fighter* brand, with no plans for the series' return.

波动拳的历史

《街头霸王》标志性招式的进化



保留这个特别的招式是一种“信仰之跃”——它在日本玩家中并不是特别受欢迎。

THE HADOKEN WAS A building block—a strong element of the original *Street Fighter* that Akira Nishitani and Akira Yasuda wanted to retain and expand in *Street Fighter II*. But keeping the special move required a leap of faith, as it didn't seem especially popular with Japanese players. On a trip to the United States, however, Nishitani noticed American players reveled in the thrill of a well-timed fireball, providing the assurance he needed to make the moves a cornerstone of the followup game.

The task of animating Ryu, Ken and their fireballs for *Street Fighter II* (as well as crafting the game's logo) was assigned to a young artist named Shoel Okano, who examined how the moves had played out in 1987's *Street Fighter*. He noticed something about the Hadoken: the

move came off very casually for Ryu, with an easy two-handed fling.

Okano decided that the updated version should require a little more exertion. He started drawing, but struggled to hit on a version that satisfied Yasuda.

“There was lots of trial and error,” recalls Okano. “Mr. Yasuda would say ‘This one has a weird smile,’ or ‘This one has a weird pose—Ryu looks drunk.’”

Okano's solution involved an elaborate windup to the Hadoken, as Ryu leaned back and pulled his hands all the way across his body before surging forward. “We made him put his hips into it. And because the move doesn't have good natural rhythm, we tried to make it like he was retreating but also going forward.”

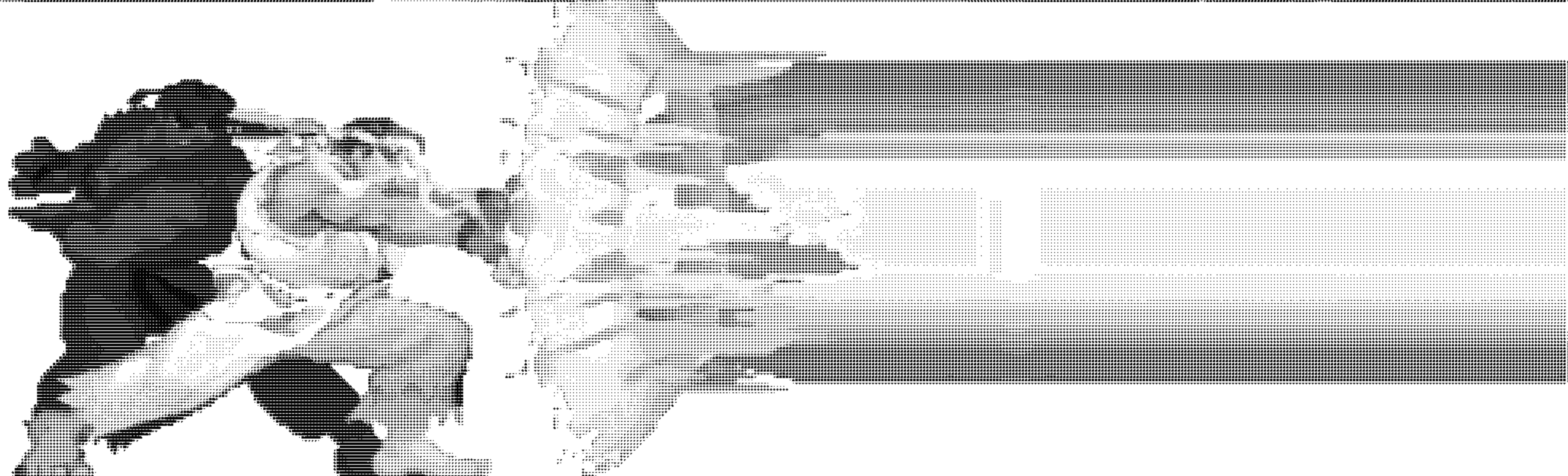
After wincing as his elaborately animated moves were reduced to just a few frames in order to decrease the game's memory load, Okano watched along with Nishitani and Yasuda as the game was released.

Street Fighter II didn't achieve the same instant arcade success in Japan that it did in the U.S. It wasn't until the first console version was released that the game caught fire with Japanese players, and not until then could Yasuda sense the impact of the revamped fireball and uppercut.

“I didn't really realize the game had become a hit until I started hearing kids on the train yelling ‘Hadoken!’” Yasuda recalls. “That's when I knew.”

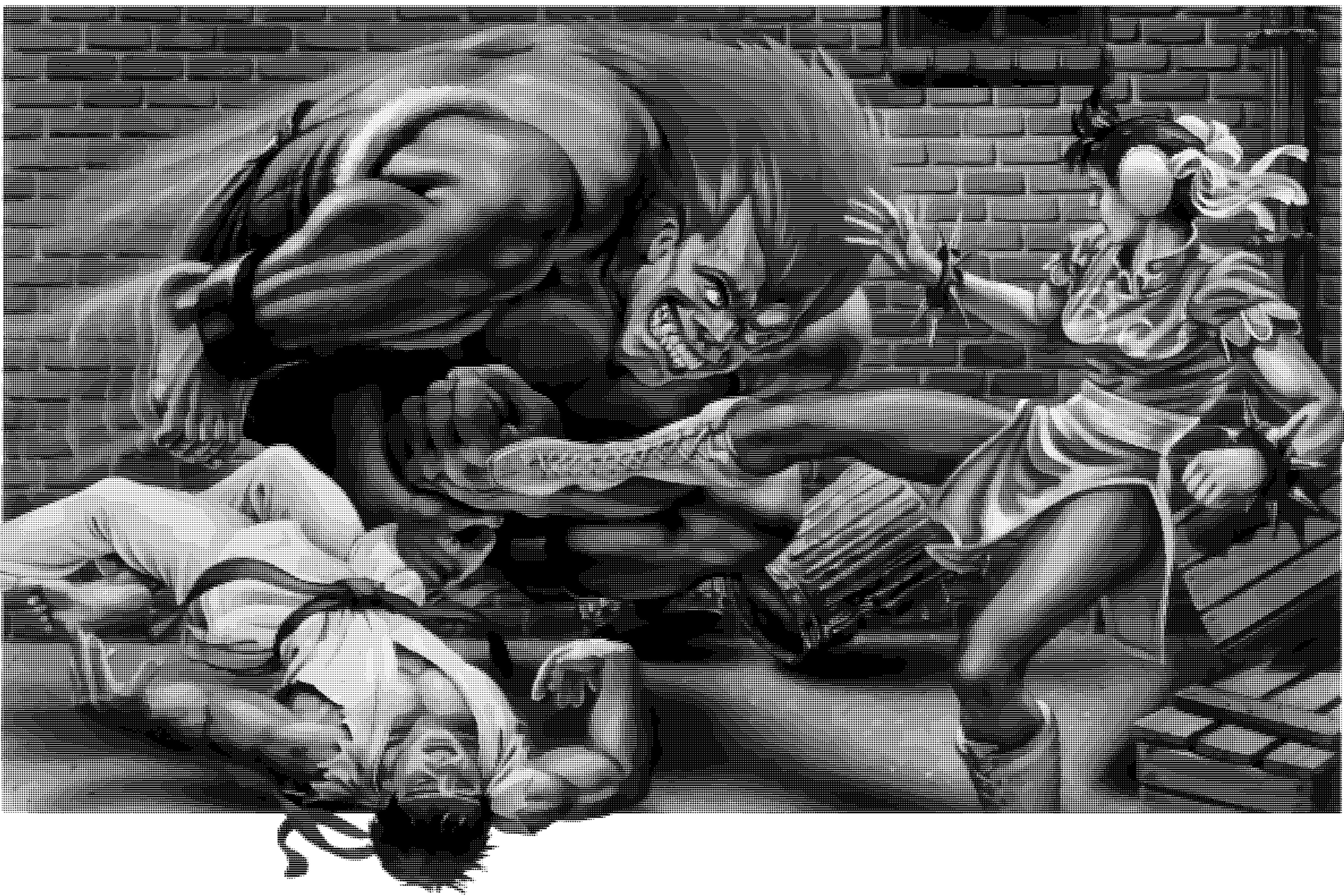


在过去的三十年里,隆的波动拳不断进化.决定性的《街头霸王II》版是由SHOEI动画化的.



东方与西方

《街头霸王II》的美国市场部如何打造属于自己的形象



STREET FIGHTER'S AESTHETIC HAS long been a fascinating amalgam of Japanese and Western styles.

"It was like a hybrid style that happened before hybrid styles existed—the first time you saw American-style characters intermixing with Japanese-style characters," says artist Alvin Lee, who worked on Udon's *Street Fighter* comics in the 2000s and now works on Riot Games' *League of Legends*. "It was so fresh at the time it was developed, and so appealing to both audiences."

That's all true—but the hybrid style employed by Akira Yasuda and his *Street Fighter II* team didn't make immediate fans of their colleagues on

either side of the Pacific. In Japan, the younger *Street Fighter Alpha* team pushed for a more Japanese, anime-inspired look for that followup series, while in the U.S., Capcom sales chief Jeff Walker thought *Street Fighter II* wouldn't sell unless its arcade cabinet (and console-port packaging) got a Western makeover.

Anime-inspired Japanese illustration from that era differed from Western comic book-style art by prioritizing emotion and tone, often by emphasizing exaggerated facial expressions. Work done in the West was more likely to feature rich, detailed textures, along with a greater emphasis on realistic propositions and anatomical accuracy.

Walker had worked at Nintendo before joining Capcom, and he thought Nintendo's youthful brand of anime missed the mark with a certain section of American players. He was concerned about an artistic disconnect between *Street Fighter II* and an American audience "that wanted blood and guts, and a tough, violent game. I had to make sure there was a harder edge, so that kids would put that first quarter in."

That instinct ultimately led Capcom to California illustrator Mick McGinty, who was hired to create packaging art for the console versions of *Street Fighter II*, as well as arcade cabinet art for *Super Street Fighter II Turbo*.



卡普空的杰夫·沃克担心《街头霸王II》与美国受众所要的“粗犷暴力游戏”之间存在美术风格的落差“violent game.”

从自由撰稿人跻身明星

Mick McGinty scored a dream job immediately after graduating from the Art Center College of Design in Pasadena, California, in 1979: he joined Willardson & White, the new Santa Monica studio of superstar airbrush artists Charles E. White III and David Willardson. Willardson worked frequently for Disney; White had done high-profile illustrations for the Rolling Stones and The Who's rock-opera *Tommy*.

McGinty hadn't planned to get into airbrush work. But Willardson & White was turning down four jobs for every one it could handle, so it decided to hire three young artists to take on the extra projects.

"They kept us busy non-stop for three years," McGinty recalls. As a result, McGinty was able to build a portfolio of high-profile client work in a flash, including an album cover for The Police and the first poster for MTV.

After four years at Willardson & White, McGinty broke off on his own. As a freelance illustrator, he crafted posters for Super Bowl

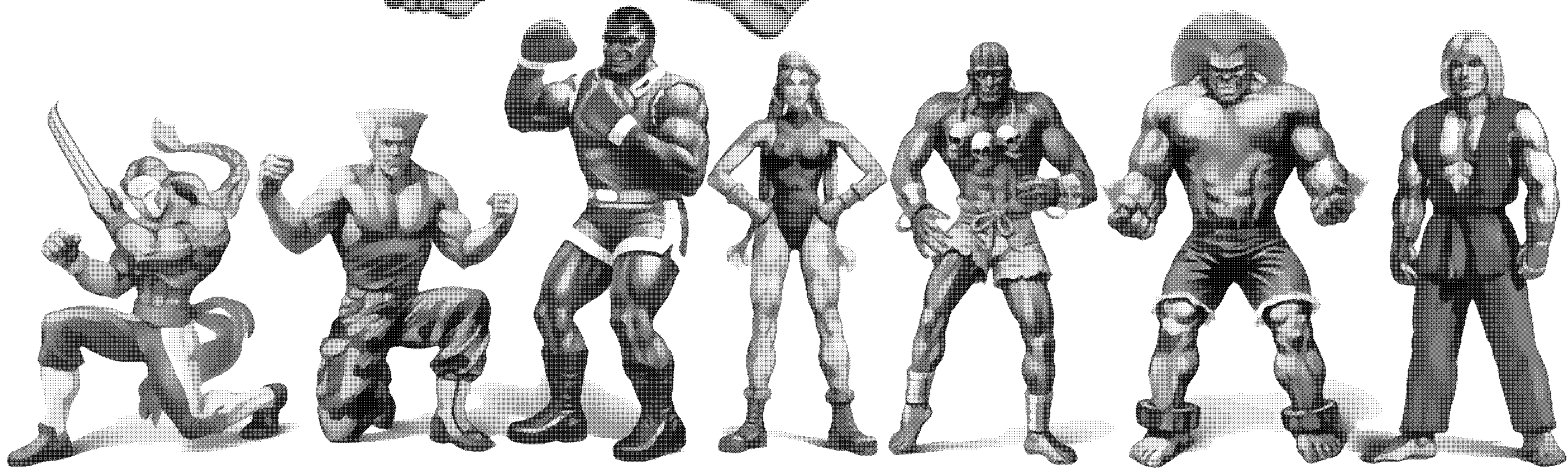
XXXIV and the movie *Who Framed Roger Rabbit*, as well as album artwork for Whitesnake and Earth, Wind & Fire. He also connected with a design house located a few hours north that had a steady stream of video-game projects, Palo Alto-based Moore & Price Design Group.

Denny Moore traveled regularly to Japan and worked with Japanese game studios including Capcom, so it was no surprise when Jeff Walker's request for a Western take on *Street Fighter II* art led to a contract with Moore & Price. Nor was it a shock when Moore turned to McGinty to execute the job. The challenge for McGinty was that he was given little guidance: Polaroid photos of people playing *Street Fighter II* at an arcade in Japan, which he scanned to get a sense of the game's backgrounds; and basic style sheets to help him understand what the characters looked like.

But the lack of instruction didn't hinder McGinty. His first effort for *Street Fighter II* was also one of his most memorable: the *Street Fighter II* cover for the Super Nintendo



左上:《街霸II》时代的春丽,分别由卡普空的西村絹(左)和美国画师米克·麦金蒂绘制;右上:麦金蒂在工作室里;右下:《街头霸王II》超任卡带上的麦金蒂作品。



Entertainment System, which depicts Blanka bowling his way through a dark alley, knocking down Ryu and Chun-Li like pins.

"That was the one I enjoyed the most, and I had all kinds of freedom to do whatever I wanted," recalls McGinty. "I just started doing sketches, airbrushing and having a blast. It was a real craft back then, in the analog days."

McGinty began the process by faxing an initial concept sketch to Moore. Those sketches were always quickly approved, and constituted the bulk of the communication between McGinty and Moore—the two never actually met in person.

Once his concept was approved, McGinty began to execute the final product. He started with a pencil sketch to rough the characters

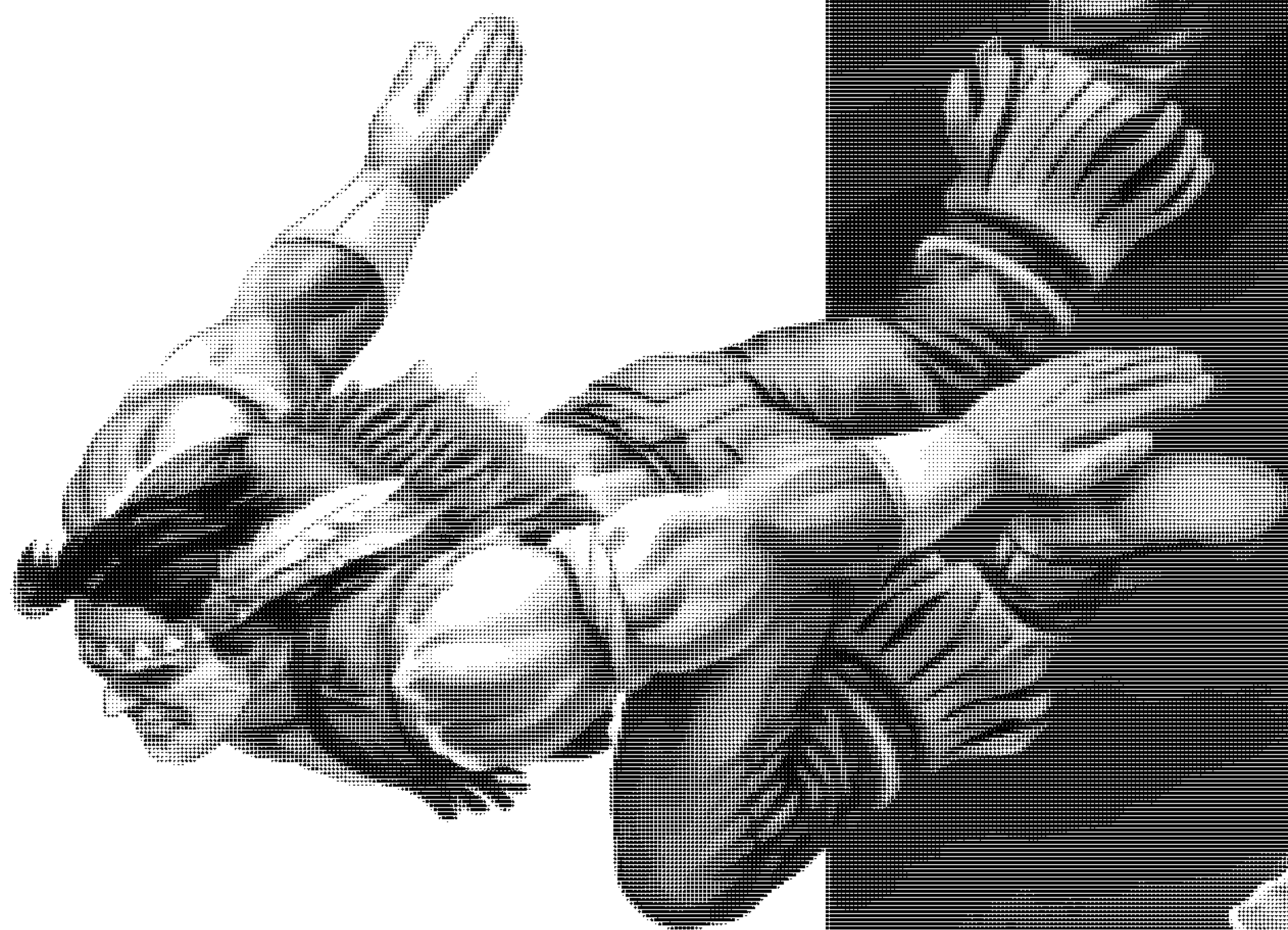
in place, then built out the world behind them, adding depth and texture to the background. Then came detailed work on the characters themselves, followed by vibrant color that brought the scene to life.

"Mostly, it was just 'Use your imagination and add the Americanization,'" recalls McGinty. For the *Street Fighter II* poster, he created a rich, textured scene, and decided to focus attention on a rolling Blanka. The whole thing came together quickly, and Capcom reps in both the U.S. and Japan were thrilled with the result. McGinty's image soon graced a red-hot product when the SNES version of *Street Fighter II* hit stores in the summer of 1992, just a couple of months after *Street Fighter II: Champion Edition* replaced the original version

of *Street Fighter II* in arcades.

McGinty repeated the process again and again, including the creation of a memorable image of M. Bison kicking Guile that graced the cover of the 1993 Sega Genesis version of *Street Fighter II: Special Champion Edition*. That same year, he produced another iconic cover for the SNES version of *Street Fighter II: Turbo*, this time with E. Honda rapid-punching Sagat into submission in Honda's famous bathhouse stage. In all, McGinty did several dozen *Street Fighter* pieces that helped the series become a massive hit in the U.S.

McGinty knows that Western pop-culture tastes have changed over the years, becoming much more receptive to Japanese illustration, and that if *Street Fighter II* were released



前页上:米克·麦金蒂为《街头霸王II》极速版所画的封面图;前页下:麦金蒂画的《街头霸王II》附图;右图:美国画师李·麦克劳德为《任天堂力量》杂志画的《街头霸王II》时代插图。

today, no one would be calling to replace the Japanese art.

"Nobody at that time understood how elegant and cool that Japanese art was. I didn't even like it back then," he says. In the years since, McGinty has "become a big fan of Japanese illustration—there's such a style to it, such a unique color and dynamic," he says.

But he also remembers the prevailing taste and sentiment of the era in which he worked on *Street Fighter II*, and that it felt like a no-brainer to re-imagine the *Street Fighter* characters in a more American style.

"You just knew for sure that if they tried to market that Japanese illustration look in America, most kids wouldn't go for it. I got the project and thought, 'Yeah, let me do some muscular guys and jump kicks and speed lines,'" McGinty recalls.

That approach represents a unique chapter in the 30-year history of *Street Fighter* art, one that differs from the games' animation style as well as from the overseas packaging art. In America, McGinty's early '90s work captured the imaginations of millions of players, and for many Super Nintendo owners, McGinty's *Street Fighter II* cover was the single, defining image of the series. McGinty not only helped to make *Street Fighter* a transcendent brand, but his images are fixed into the collective consciousness of a generation of gamers.









藏宝库

克拉伦斯·林创世界记录的《街头霸王》收藏

上图:克拉伦斯·林与他的《街头霸王》收藏品;下图:克拉伦斯·林和他的妻子坎迪丝扮成了隆与樱。



THE WORLD'S LARGEST COLLECTION of Street Fighter memorabilia—certified by Guinness World Records—belongs to Clarence Lim of Mississauga, Ontario. If it says Street Fighter, Lim probably has it: factory-sealed console games, movies, action figures, comics, artwork and even rare gems such as a Where's Waldo-esque book called *Look and Find Street Fighter II*.

There's also a homemade item in Lim's collection: the costume he created to cosplay as Ryu.

"Cosplay is an expression of love for a character and franchise," says Lim, who has been devoted to Ryu since he began playing Street Fighter games as a kid. "He fights for the sake of fighting—to better himself as a fighter, and to become the best version of himself. That simplicity and focus resonated in me."

In addition to demonstrating his devotion to Street Fighter through cosplay, the hobby has provided Lim with a unique opportunity to meet like-minded fans. He often cosplays as part of a

group, and uses it to meet new friends as well. "It's a great icebreaker, because you're meeting others like you who love and appreciate similar things," Lim says.

Lim even met his wife, Candace, through cosplay. Candace was cosplaying as Sakura—Ryu's protegee—when they met in 2009. Candace is a video-game memorabilia collector as well, and now the combined Lim family collection (which isn't limited to Street Fighter) numbers several thousand items.

Collecting will always be Clarence Lim's primary Street Fighter-related passion, but cosplay is a close second. It's a passion driven by moments like one that happened last year at a Toronto convention. Lim was cosplaying as Ryu when a six-year-old boy tugged on his glove and pointed to his father.

"His father asked if I could have my photo taken with his son because I was the boy's hero," remembers Lim. After the snapshot, "We both walked off with huge smiles on our faces."



左图:两瓶泰尼·勒贝尔的“波动拳”淡艾尔啤酒;右图:泰尼·勒贝尔的联合创始人们。



波动拳(淡艾尔啤酒)的苦涩冲击

泰尼·勒贝尔的精酿致敬了《街头霸王》

WHEN WELSH BREWERS GAZZ Williams and Brad Cummings were preparing to sell their first pints to the public nine years ago, they wanted to create a brand that reflected their personalities. So they named their Newport, Wales-based brewery Tiny Rebel, and then set out to give their beers names that evoked their '90s childhoods.

"We both grew up video-gaming, and of course loved Street Fighter. And we had this big, punchy, amplified IPA that needed a name," says Williams. "It was a perfect match for our favorite move from the game."

Hadouken IPA is now one of Tiny Rebel's

mainstays. Its label features the quarter-circle command necessary to generate a fireball in Street Fighter, but at first, Tiny Rebel's designer accidentally inverted the design.

"Right away, some guy came up to us at a beer festival in Cardiff and said, 'Hey, your arrows are wrong!'" Williams recalls. The error was soon corrected.

Hadouken IPA is Tiny Rebel's best-known Street Fighter-inspired beer, but not the only one. Williams and Cummings brewed a rye-heavy cask ale in 2015 called Ryu, and there's one in the works that recalls Chun-Li's trademark move: the Spinning Bird Kick.

卡迪夫啤酒节上,某个人走到我们面前说:嘿,你们的箭头印错了!(已改)
——加扎·威廉姆斯,泰尼·勒贝尔联合创始人

雕塑长出头发之时

朱利安·方定制人偶背后的故事 minifigs



朱利安·方正在制作《街头霸王》的定制人偶。他最新的作品是韩蛛俐(右图)。

IT WAS HAIR THAT compelled Julian Fong to create custom Street Fighter Lego mini-figures in the first place. And it was hair that drove him crazy.

Fong had been painting and sculpting minifigs based on comic-book characters when he bought a loose pack of Lego pieces to see if anything inside would help streamline his creative process. The bag contained a sumo wrestler's topknot, and Fong instantly thought of E. Honda from Street Fighter. Minifig

hair often had to be sculpted by hand from modeling clay, making it the most challenging component of his job, so the prospect of a pre-made Honda hairdo was appealing. Fong kept digging through the bag and found a mohawk that would work for Zangief, along with pieces that suited Ryu and Ken, and soon he was off and running on a small Street Fighter series.

The only problem? Fong's addiction to minifig completism.

"Once I had four, I had to finish all of them," says the Bay Area software engineer.

Soon he encountered an ironic problem: his old nemesis—hair—had followed

him into his new project and was more challenging than ever. "Hair was the biggest issue

because that's a huge part of what makes the *Street Fighter II* character designs so memorable," he says. "Just think about Guile and Blanka, and whether those characters would come across without their hair."

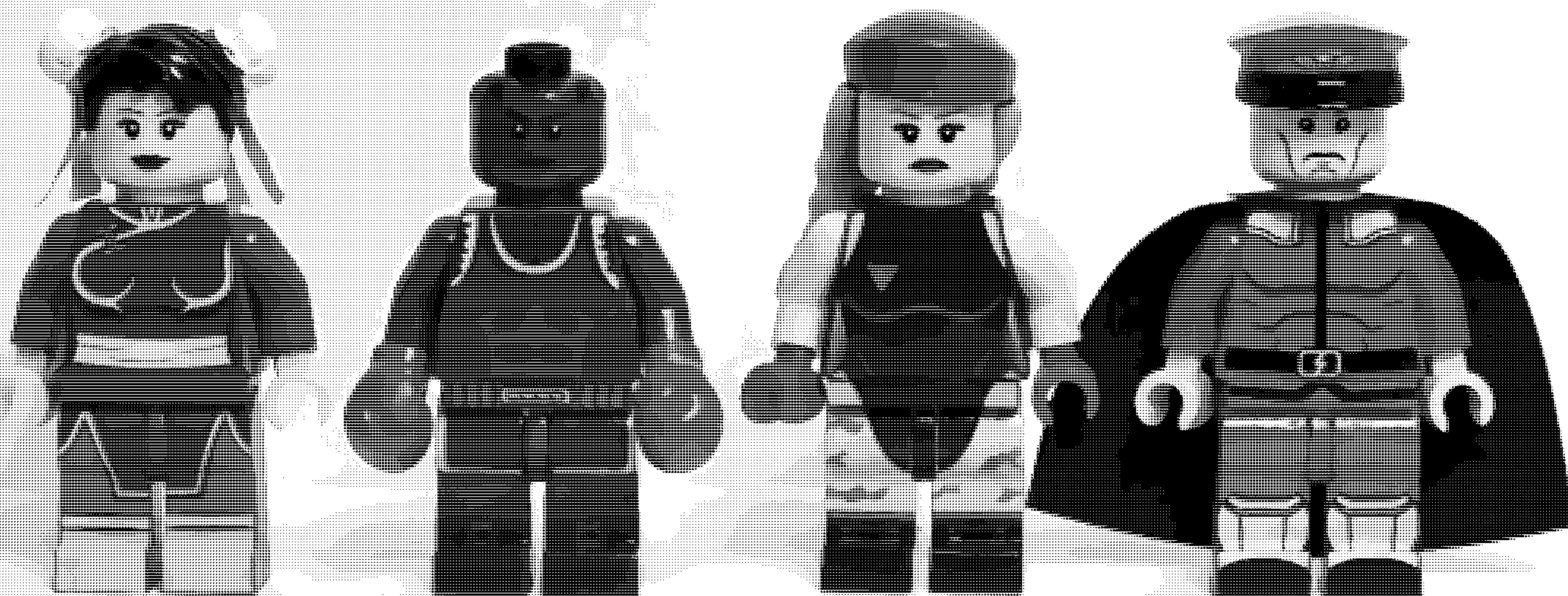
True—yet neither Guile nor Blanka ranks among the most challenging or rewarding figures in Fong's series. That honor goes to the best-known women of Street Fighter.

"Cammy and Chun-Li have ridiculous yet iconic hairstyles, and it was clear that nothing out of the box would work," says Fong. "I dithered on those two characters for a year, hoping that Lego would issue some hair that could be repurposed. That actually happened with Cammy—Lego issuing a collectible minifig with pigtails, whose hair I gleefully chopped off, glued to a beret and painted."

Fong then sculpted Chun-Li's hair and exhaled. He had finished his Street Fighter series.

Or so he thought. That was 2012, and Fong soon realized that there were too many cool Street Fighter characters he hadn't included in his initial series. He's made dozens of Street Figures since, and remains at work. His latest creation is Juri, completed this spring.





角色COS的艺术(及技巧)

林茨·梅丽特如何成为了卧底“深红毒蛇”

LINDZE MERRITT DISCOVERED COSPLAY when she decided to sew her own costume for a Halloween party in the late '90s. The experience sent her tumbling down a rabbit hole of obsessive theatricality.

"When I get into something, I tend to dive in headfirst," says Merritt.

Street Fighter was her favorite series, but she couldn't find a character that felt right until the release of *Street Fighter IV* in 2008. Newcomer C. Viper was a perfect match.

"She's a badass, and also a mom—not some tee-hee girly-girl," explains Merritt. "I'm a mom, and also 5'9" and curvy, so the tee-hee thing really doesn't fit me, and I loved that C. Viper didn't need cuteness to be awesome."

Merritt decided to cosplay C. Viper at Dragon Con 2011, a large pop-culture convention near her home in Atlanta. She set about constructing her costume with the devotion to detail that is a hallmark of serious cosplay.

The first step was a trip to the thrift store, where Merritt bought a jacket and pants that she then altered to be more form-fitting.

C. Viper's shirt wasn't so simple. Merritt made it from scratch.

"At first glance, it just looks like a dress shirt with cleavage, but it's not. It has cups like a bathing suit, and tuxedo styling in the ribcage area," says Merritt. She used a white twill with a slight give to it, "so that it would stretch without looking like spandex."

Next came the accessories. C. Viper's glasses posed a particular challenge because they don't have temples. The lenses "just sort of float magically," says Merritt, who used clear fishing wire and spirit gum to replicate the effect. Merritt also welded custom earrings from sheet metal. The makeup, at least, was easy—Merritt is a professional makeup artist.

Two challenges remained. The first was to reproduce C. Viper's extra-thick, extra-long auburn hair; the second was to replicate the

character's enviable abs. Merritt French-braided her own hair, and also constructed an elaborate pompadour with a felt base, then braided the two together before using hair cement to add the final touch—a little curl that stretches forward over the character's right eye.

But the art of costuming provided no shortcut to achieving Street Fighter-grade abs. "I started working out a year in advance," says Merritt. "It was a nightly routine of 50 bicycle crunches and 50 reverse crunches. And it worked."

In cosplay, Merritt found a vehicle to express her love of favorite characters, as well as a community of friends. Her exuberance for the hobby doesn't sound quite in-character for C. Viper, but is genuine all the same.

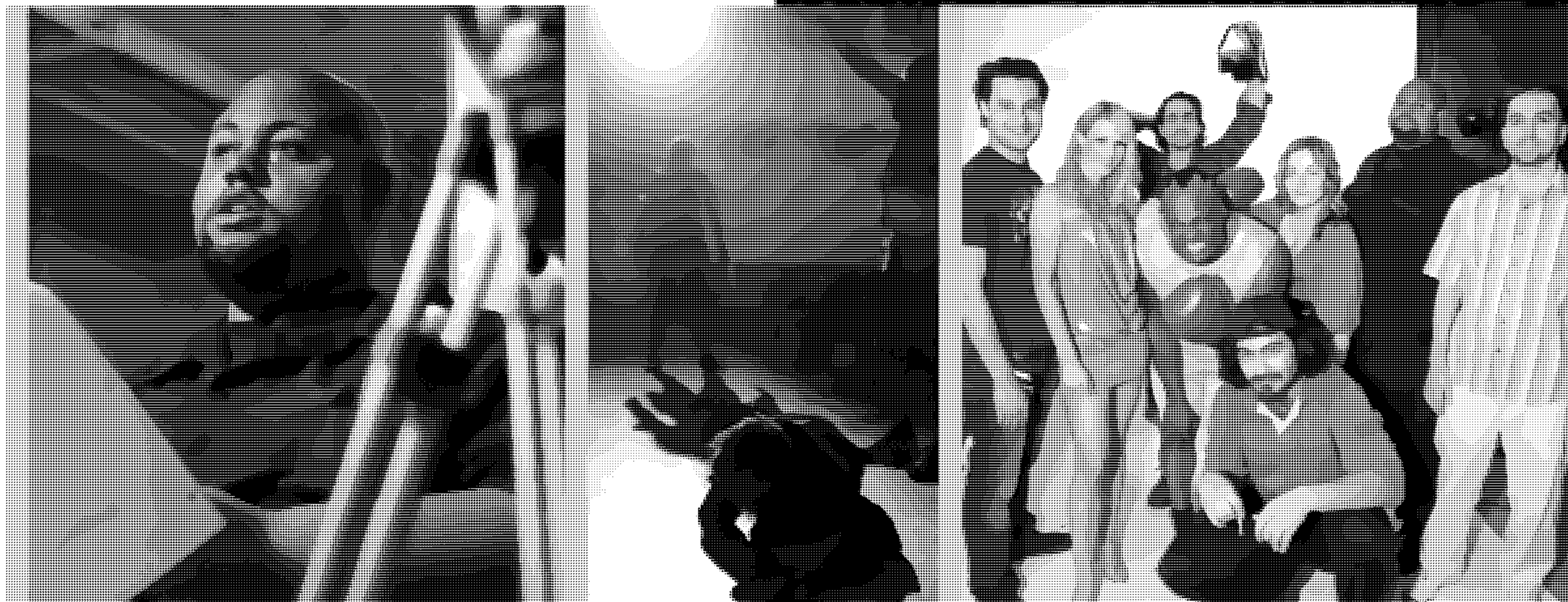
"Joining this community has given me friends, experiences, travel, career opportunities, and best of all, more fun than I can shake a stick at," Merritt gushes.

下页图:计划进行顺利,林茨·梅丽特穿上了深红毒蛇的战斗服。

我喜爱深红毒蛇,她帅气到不需要可爱了。
——林茨·梅丽特







绝妙的背景故事

编剧布雷特·巴约纳让巴洛克与维加栩栩如生

左至右:编剧布雷特·巴约纳;维加俯视着他的牺牲品;巴约纳(后排右二)、导演瓦赫·葛布奇安(中间)与《巴洛克》演职人员。

SEVEN-YEAR-OLD BRETT BAYONNE WOULD tag along with his mother when she headed to the bowling alley near their central Los Angeles home in the early 1990s. While his mom took aim at strikes and spares, he would wander over to the arcade, where a collection of four *Street Fighter II* machines always drew a crowd.

"It was always packed, and I would feel intimidated—but not intimidated enough to walk away," he recalls. "I would wait my turn and then start mashing buttons while some older kid gave me side-eye."

Nearly two decades later, in 2010, Bayonne was a screenwriter who, along with director Vahé Gabuchian, devised an idea for a short film: a deadpan mockumentary that told the purported backstory of Balrog, one of *Street Fighter*'s mainstay villains.

"At that point, Balrog had been around for almost as long as me, and he had this flimsy parody of a history. Our approach to telling his story was that we were going to say yes to everything in his over-the-top backstory and make it all make sense. We wanted to make every detail important."

The resulting 12-minute film tells the tale of a scrawny, bullied boy who gets an extremely

angular haircut and ultimately falls in with the wrong crowd—the international crime syndicate Shadaloo. It could be tragic, except that it's about Balrog from *Street Fighter*, a buffoonish character who always wears his boxing gloves, in or out of the ring.

When the film, *Balrog: Behind the Glory*, premiered before an audience of thousands at the 2011 EVO fighting-game championships in Las Vegas, it was a cool moment for Bayonne, who saw his love of filmmaking and *Street Fighter* come together: "It was a special chance to see my passions cross streams with one another," he says.

After the warm reception for *Balrog*, Bayonne and Gabuchian decided to try again. They chose Spanish villain Vega as the subject of their 2014 followup. The resulting film, *Matador*, was much darker than its predecessor.

"When we were researching Vega, we found this backstory of his stepfather murdering his mother, and that got the gears turning. I mean, what a formative moment. He's probably got all kinds of issues," says Bayonne. "So we decided to do it as a thriller. It was like, 'We're the guys who made that funny Balrog movie,' and this was something very different. But I'm satisfied

we did justice to the character."

In the *Street Fighter* games, Vega is obsessed with beauty. He waxes poetic about it before slashing at his opponents, walking a fine line between trademark and schtick. But Bayonne's script took that absurdist character trait to a very dark, powerful place: In the moments just before she dies, Vega's mother exhorts her son not be an ugly person like his stepfather, turning Vega's obsession with beauty into a referendum on character rather than outward appearance. To see that suggestion work its way into the eyes of a young, future villain is a powerful moment of grown-up, narrative pathos. It's all the more remarkable for having come from *Street Fighter*'s playful roots.

When the lights came up at EVO, Bayonne glanced nervously around the room to gauge the crowd's reaction. The film didn't land quite like *Balrog: Behind the Glory*, but then it wasn't supposed to. "If *Balrog* was like a big box-office blockbuster, this was more of a cult hit," Bayonne says. "It wasn't what people were expecting, but I think we found that right balance between satisfying the audience and challenging them."

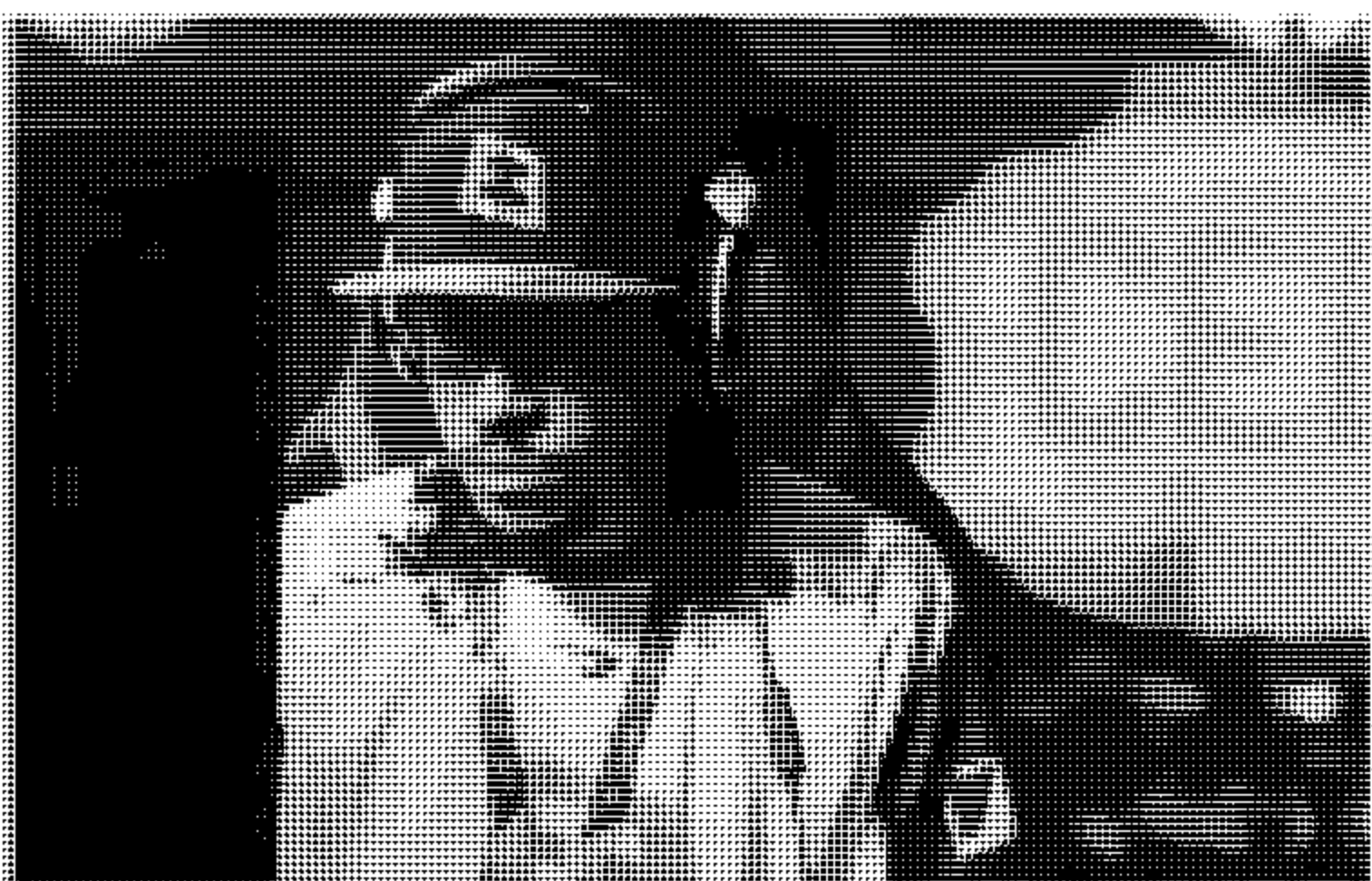


左至右:M.拜森结识了维加;年幼的维加发生转变的时刻;长大后的维加;巴洛克的父亲(上图有误,显然片子是日版圆不回去了);年幼的巴洛克学会了永远不要摘下手套;巴洛克打出一记右勾拳;下图:巴洛克击倒了对手。

“我们准备好接受有关巴洛克所有夸张的背景故事,并让它能够讲得通。”

——布雷特·巴约纳,《巴洛克》编剧





透过克里斯·巴恩的镜头

译注:这位老兄因为性骚扰已经凉了

CHRIS "BAHN" SCANTLEBERRY GREW up playing Street Fighter in New York City, competing in tournaments and at famous venues such as Eight on the Break in Dunellen, New Jersey.

After a few years as a competitor, he had an idea: to transform himself into a multimedia fighting games photographer and journalist. "Nobody was really covering fighting games at the time," he says. "It's just something I thought was lacking, so I started to do it myself."

He started by video-recording interviews with top players. The response was positive, and soon he was buying more gear, honing his craft and building a business, PTB Photo.

He traveled to tournaments around the country and chronicled the competitions and personalities.

"I learned to really value capturing the player's emotions, and to show what they're experiencing," says Scantleberry. He excels at portraying the spirit of the fighting-game community, whether it's the intensity and excitement of a dramatic match, the creativity and style of a cosplayer, or just the camaraderie that defines the tournament scene.

And as the Street Fighter community continues to grow, Scantleberry has an ever-richer subject to portray. "It's just amazing to see the evolution," he says.

CHRIS "Bahn" Scantleberry (below) is a leading photographer and journalist covering the Street Fighter community.





INFINITE

24小时铸就《第3次冲击》的永恒

INFINITE WAS ALREADY ONE of Canada's top rappers when he got an invitation to a short-notice audition in Toronto in 1998—the chance to rap in *Street Fighter III: 3rd Strike*. It was a thrilling opportunity for someone who had grown up playing *Street Fighter*.

There was worthy competition at the audition, too. Infinite, whose real name is Dale Francis, recognized several guys who, like him, had won JUNO Awards—the Canadian Grammys. All of them had to rap over an up-tempo backing track. “It was definitely video-game speed,” Francis recalls. “It was like twice the speed of what I was used to working with, but it clicked.”

Francis won the job. Had this been a normal competition, he might have next taken a moment to celebrate. Instead, though, he learned that his prize was even more stressful than the audition: he had 24 hours to compose three original songs from scratch, to be rehearsed and recorded the following day.

Francis returned to his Toronto home, grabbed a notebook and pen, and sat down on the floor by his bed.

“I thought there was no way I could do it. I was just feeling like, ‘This opportunity is going to slip and pass me by, like it wasn’t going to be possible.’ But then I just decided to make it possible. I started writing and didn’t stop until I was finished—it was blood, sweat and tears that night.”

Eventually, lyrics started pouring forth, ranging from a memorable hook (“Make your first move—what’s it gonna be? You’re trapped in the new world of *Street Fighter III*”) to a line that spoke to Francis’ immediate circumstances (“Battle this style to the twenty-fourth hour”). It was a career-defining moment for Francis, who continues to write, record and release music as Infinite.

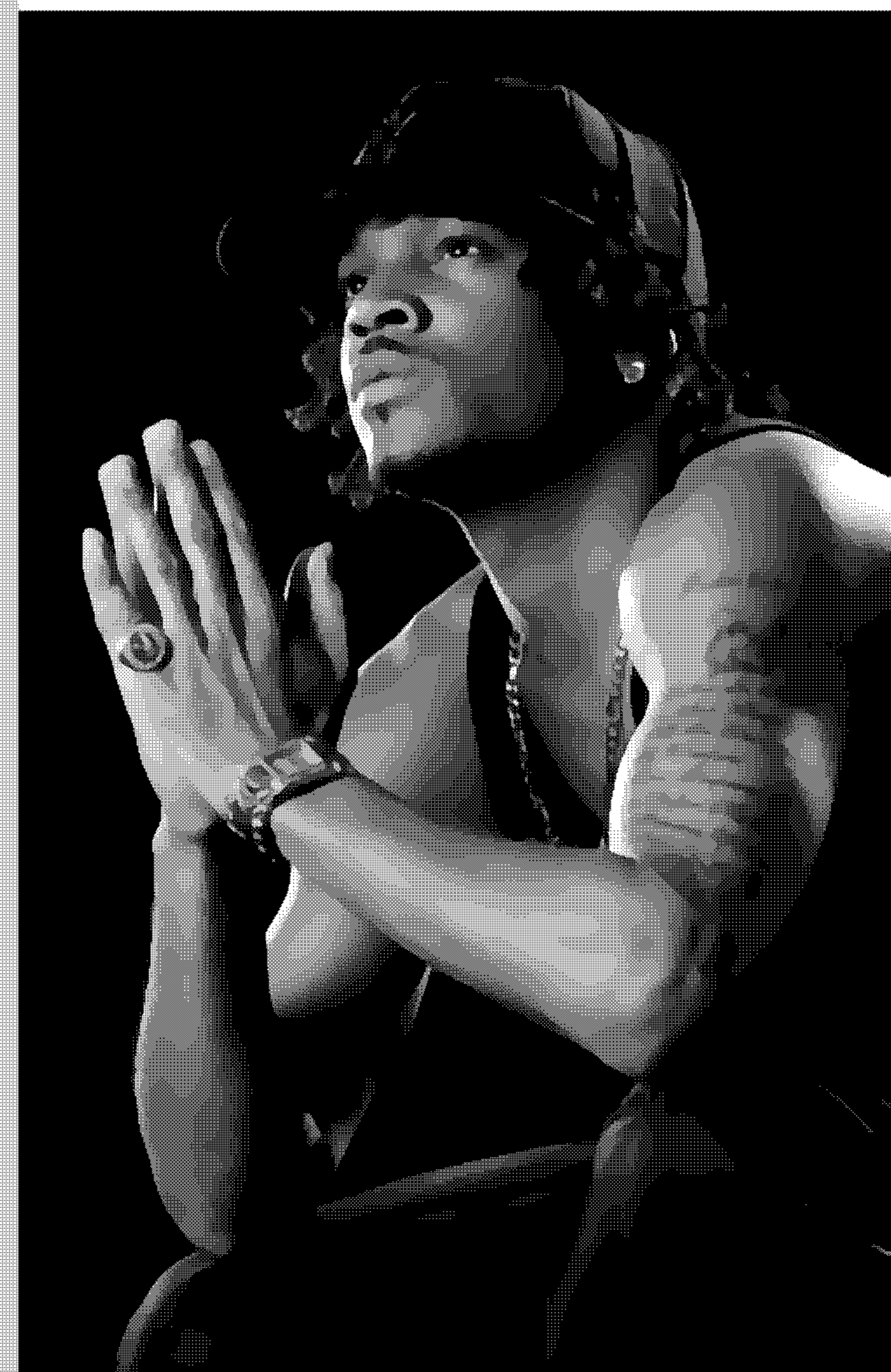
The game debuted in 1999, featuring Infinite’s three songs, as well as his ringside-announcer call: “Round One ... Fight!”

Francis knew he was part of something special when he walked by the arcade at a Toronto mall. “Somebody came out and was like ‘Yo, I was playing *Street Fighter* and there’s a guy on there who sounds like you!’”

“

我一口气写完,中间没有停顿—那一晚混合着血汗与泪水。

—INFINITE



INFINITE在整晚为《第3次冲击》写歌后不久拍摄的照片。